

Chapter 9

Geopolitical Tensions and Multilateral Solutions



The world has always been and continues to change, going through periods of relative peace and relative upheaval. Recent history shows that major global shifts in power seem to be coming in more frequent succession due to the fact that our world in a figurative sense is becoming smaller and smaller. The time it takes to travel to or send a message is a fraction of what our ancestors could have even imagined a century ago.

The increased interactions of different peoples from different corners of the world with different cultural and political systems are bound to ultimately produce tension on some level. Globalization as a phenomenon has contributed to both the prosperity of the human race as well as its tendency toward conflict or crisis. In just the last 80 years, this has been exemplified by the extent of the Second World War, which touched nearly every corner of the world simultaneously, the prosperity of the post-war era in the United States and Europe, the tension of the Cold War and the fall of the Soviet Union, China's meteoric rise as a global economic powerhouse, the shock waves sent through the world during multiple financial crises around the turn of the millennium, and most recently the COVID-19 pandemic, which nearly paralyzed the entire world.

As we prepare for the next phase in global evolution, geopolitical tensions, specifically between the United States and China as the world's two most powerful nations, but also within specific regions, present both challenges and opportunities. As global institutions and partnerships struggle to keep pace with the times and establish new methods to adapt to transformations in global power structures as well as global threats like climate change and data security, the line between national interests and human security is possibly more consequential than ever before in human history.

However, the fact that the world is also more multilateral and inclusive than at most other points in history provides a glimmer of hope for humanity. If the nations of the world, especially great powers, can look past their individual interests and focus on the greater welfare of the world as a whole, we may be able to move past

current geopolitical tensions and leverage multilateral efforts to ensure a more secure and prosperous future.

Multilateralism from China's Perspective

If we assume that a multilateral solution to the problems the world currently faces is the best option, we must strengthen the institutions that can contribute to those solutions. From China's perspective, it has a key role not only in contributing to these solutions, but also in advocating for the interests of its fellow Global South nations. The first article in this chapter, titled "How to Fix the Security Council" and published by *Foreign Policy*, focuses on the crisis facing the UN Security Council and, by extension, the overall United Nations system. By pointing out the paralytic state of the UNSC, this article reminds us of how times have changed, and that a reckoning about how the UN can once again be made "fit for purpose" in a changing world is urgently necessary. The next article, "Transformation and Opportunities in the Multipolar Era: Regional Integration, Global Governance and China's Historical Wisdom," seeks possible inspiration for these reforms by focusing on how China's historical perspective provides a more stable and measured approach to creating a multilateral world that is beneficial to all. In place of increased confrontation through the creation of security blocs, China champions an evolution through trade to mutual respect and universal development. The third article focuses on another key international institution—the Shanghai Cooperation Organization—a collection of diverse nations that come from all backgrounds, but collectively drive the fundamental tenets of the United Nations, acting not as a countermeasure to the current global order and its institutions, but as a bulwark that maintains its values and principles amid a global system that is increasingly functionally paralyzed.

The fourth article in this chapter, "Only a Multipolar Coalition Can Secure Ukraine Peace," suggests that the Korean War Armistice Agreement could serve as a reference for resolving the Russia-Ukraine war with the support of a multipolar coalition. The next article, "The Outlook for Multilateralism Under the Shadow of Protectionism," meanwhile, highlights China's key role in the fight against protectionism in global trade by promoting more open trade among Asian nations to leverage the strength of emerging economies in Asia, specifically to combat protectionism in the United States and other developed economies. The sixth article in this chapter, titled "Toward a More Multipolar World: Sino-US-Europe Dynamics in the Trump 2.0 Era," takes a closer look at the position of the United States, and a second Trump administration in particular, on the relationship between China, the United States, and European countries in a world that is becoming irreversibly more multipolar. It also highlights the difficulties that Europe may face in this changing environment because of its historically close relationship with the United States, which has become increasingly inward looking and recalcitrant in terms of global policy. By comparison, the developing countries that make up most of the Global South generally remain enthusiastic about a more multilateral world in which continued globalization is central. The seventh article in this chapter, "China and the Global South: Unleashing the Tides of Transformation in the Global Order," focuses on how these countries will

be key in future changes in the global order and how their values, systems, and unique needs will shape this transformation.

The Global South, including BRICS member countries, view traditionally Western institutions like NATO as being focused on individual security rather than overall human security, which is the topic of the eighth article in this chapter, “Alliances Like NATO Are out of Touch with a World in Need of Human Security.” This chapter highlights the fact that existing institutions were founded to ensure the security of the leading nations of the world, which were then charged with managing global peace, rather than including the developing, or newly independent, world in a conversation on an even playing field.

Great Power Relations and Mechanisms for Communication

The most contentious relationship, yet the one with the most potential in the world today, is that between China and the United States. The first- and second-largest economies in the world with perhaps the greatest combined political influence in the world, these are truly two great powers and have the ability, as well as the responsibility, to shape the future of the world.

However, their vast difference in histories, ideologies, and visions for the future of the world often put these two countries at odds. China’s incredible economic rise has not only made China wealthy and given it greater influence among its trading partners, but it has also resulted in an interdependence with the United States that is so inseparable that they have been described as Siamese twins. While recent reshoring and derisking efforts have been working to mitigate this reliance, it has been difficult as many companies are already established in China.

Despite the seemingly unresolvable issues and persistent trade war environment that exists today, the ninth article in this chapter, titled “As US-China Rivalry Heats Up, Soft Power Competition Need Not Be a Zero-Sum Game,” the conflict and a long-term rivalry between the world’s two biggest economies should not prevent them from working together on issues that affect the entire world.

As with many relationships, direct conversation can sometimes make things worse, and there are times at which an intermediary can facilitate a kind of *détente*. In this next article, “A Close-Up Look at New Trends in China-US-EU Relations,” we look at the role that the EU can play to create a balance in geopolitical relations. The EU’s close relationship with the United States and its practically amicable relationship with China puts it in a position to facilitate discussions to work on issue-based solutions that benefit everyone.

In the wake of the Second World War, the United States has maintained a global reach militarily, politically, and economically that has remained essentially unrivaled, especially after the fall of the Soviet Union. However, China’s economic rise and perceived political and military rise has caused concern in the United States, which has regularly used a policy of containment with respect to China. This remained true through the Biden administration, which we examine in the eleventh article in this chapter, titled “Biden’s Indo-Pacific Framework Cannot Succeed without China.” The constant vacillation in US policy with regard to East Asia has created uncertainty and a lack of credibility among nations in the region. While Asian nations welcome

US engagement in the region, they would rather not have to choose between China and the United States in the course of that engagement.

In the midst of bilateral bickering and trilateral tinkering, the best solution would be a multilateral one that includes as many voices as possible. In the twelfth article in this chapter, titled “How a ‘G3’ Mechanism Could Reset US-China-EU Relations and Tackle Global Challenges,” we focus on the suggestion of CCG experts to establish a “G3 mechanism” that would foster communication between the three most influential regional powers in the world in order to better facilitate and coordinate efforts to deal with challenges that face the world as a whole.

Beyond West and East—Engaging the Global South

In today’s multilateral world, the general consensus is that the world should progress together as a whole, with wealthier and more powerful nations supporting the developing world. In the context of China and the United States, or even Russia and Europe, the world is often divided into East and West, but moving beyond those traditional geographic markers, we find that some of the most vibrant emerging regions are in what has become known as the Global South.

While China is often considered part of the Global South, its economic success and geopolitical influence has placed it at the top of the developing world and on par with the United States and EU. As a quasi “*primus inter paribus*” among developing nations, China’s strengthening relations with the Global South have been consistently bearing fruit in terms of new cooperation models, improved regional relations and recognition among developing nations. In the thirteenth article in this chapter, “China’s Ties with the Global South Show a Different World Order Is Possible,” shows how countries from the Caribbean to Central Africa approve of China’s approach to trade and partnership vis-à-vis Western countries, which have also begun to pull traditional support due to changing policies of protectionism and putting domestic affairs first.

One of the key institutions that has been working on driving development across the Global South by the Global South is BRICS. The fourteenth article in this chapter, “BRICS Is Not Anti-West, It Just Wants a Fairer World Order,” highlights the desire of the Global South to participate in global economic governance and development on equal terms within the current system.

While sometimes viewed as a challenge to the established power structure, it is more likely that the newly found capacity among Global South countries presents an opportunity for both sides to join hands and drive development across the board. This is the topic of the next article in this chapter, titled “How China and the West Can Join Hands to Truly Help Africa.” With the youngest population on average and an abundance of resources, the African continent has great potential for prosperity, but historical legacies and a lack of infrastructure has stymied efforts at development. If China, which has worked to develop infrastructure in Africa, could work with Western tech giants and international institutions, a real difference could be made in Africa.

As mentioned previously, China is potentially an ideal bridge between East and West as well as North and South. The next article in this chapter, “How China Can

Step Up to Its Responsibilities in a Rising Global South,” focuses on how China must also work to foster South-South cooperation, especially with its regional rival India, highlighting five practical areas in which it can contribute to sustainable development in the Global South. The seventh article in this chapter, titled “How Modi’s Visit to China Can Reshape Asia’s Future,” once again emphasizes the importance of improved relations between China and India as two of Asia’s most influential countries, invoking the spirit of the Bandung Conference, to which both countries were a party when it was convened in 1955.

The next article in this chapter, titled “From ASEAN and G20 to APEC, as World Leaders Meet in Person Again, Three Reasons to Root for Multilateralism,” highlights specifically how the initial meetings of these multilateral organizations post-COVID were able to reach a number of agreements on key issues, providing positive momentum for a multilateral future.

Meanwhile, China’s own multilateral efforts through its Belt and Road Initiative, while ambitious, must also continue to become more inclusive. In the nineteenth article in this chapter, titled “How China Can Multilateralize the BRI,” suggestions are given on how the initiative should move past bilateral Memoranda of Understanding to include members in its administration while also engaging with other international organizations.

Technology—The Double-Edged Sword of a Multilateral World

The final two articles look at the impact of technology on a multilateral world and how to ensure the flow of information while ensuring security and protecting privacy in the information age.

In the penultimate article of this chapter, “China Can Embrace the Global Internet for Its Narrative,” the merits of China engaging with the world through the global internet by both encouraging domestic institutions to increase their online presence beyond China’s cybersphere and by making it easier for individuals to engage with the world and change the China narrative through online exchange.

The final article focuses on the real concerns of data security in the United States and how China is attempting to reassure not only the United States, but the world as a whole, that it is equally committed to data security. “US Concerns about China’s Data Security Should Be Addressed, But Not with a TikTok Ban” outlines China’s efforts to demonstrate its respect for data sovereignty as well as the positive impact that global platforms like TikTok and others have on individual users and the economy, arguing that an outright ban would have only a negative impact.

How to Fix the Security Council¹

Adding Members and Removing the Unilateral Veto Would Make the Body Stronger.

At the 80th United Nations General Assembly high-level debates last week, a host of global leaders called for a more effective and representative Security Council. In the words of Finnish President Alexander Stubb: “If countries from the Global South, from Latin America, from Africa, from Asia, do not get agency in the system, they will turn their backs against the United Nations.”

Indeed, the Council’s shortcomings are playing out all too clearly today in Gaza and Ukraine. The United States has used its unilateral veto to block a host of resolutions calling for a ceasefire in Gaza, enabling the genocidal conflict to continue. Meanwhile, Russia has consistently blocked any meaningful Security Council response to the war in Ukraine since 2022, despite international condemnation and profound humanitarian suffering.

However, despite the Security Council’s flaws, there is no real substitute for it. If it drifts into irrelevance, this would simply remove the last vestiges of effective global coordination. The challenge, then, is not whether to reform the council, but how to do so.

It is against this backdrop that Chinese President Xi Jinping launched a new Global Governance Initiative. Xi is calling for a fairer and more inclusive multilateral system, one without double standards that places the United Nations at its core.

To realize this global vision, the Security Council should enact structural and procedural reform. First, the council should expand its membership to better reflect the world of today. Second, it should develop a mechanism to limit the use of unilateral vetoes to prevent a single state from standing athwart an international consensus. Together, these reforms can revitalize the Security Council’s credibility and capacity, transforming it from a forum of gridlock into a more responsive and effective guardian of the peace.

The Security Council’s current structure—five permanent members and 10 rotating nonpermanent members—reflects, at best, the geopolitical realities at the time of the last set of Security Council reforms in 1965. This structure should be updated by adding a new class of associate permanent member seats.

To that end, all current G21 (formerly G20) members should be given a seat on an expanded Security Council. This would eliminate the 10 existing rotating seats and create 16 new permanent associate seats. These new states would not have an individual veto, but together with the other four permanent members, they could override the use of the unilateral veto.

This would preserve the institutional legacy of the original five full members, while elevating voices that reflect today’s multipolar economic and political order. In doing so, it would enhance the Council’s legitimacy, improve regional representation, and embed the Security Council more firmly within the real architecture of the current global order.

¹ First published by *Foreign Policy* on September 30, 2025.

Previous reform efforts have stumbled over the question of how to allot new seats in the Council. Here, the G21 offers an elegant solution. It is comprised of an even mix of developed and developing countries. Using it as the basis for reform addresses some of the underrepresentation of the Global South while still recognizing the enduring power of incumbents. Today, the G21's members comprise over 85% of global GDP, and has already helped coordinate multilateral responses to some of the world's most pressing economic challenges. Under this new model the expanded UN Security Council would consist of Argentina, Australia, Brazil, Canada, China, France, Germany, India, Indonesia, Italy, Japan, South Korea, Mexico, Russia, Saudi Arabia, South Africa, Türkiye, the United Kingdom, and the United States, along with the African Union and the European Union, which would each have one collective vote.

The second reform necessary to restore function is a procedural one. The unilateral veto has created paralysis in the Security Council, allowing even urgent humanitarian measures to be stalled indefinitely. To this day, the veto has seen use a staggering total of 324 times in less than 80 years at an average rate of four vetoes a year. This includes 159 vetoes by the Soviet Union or Russian Federation, 94 by the United States, 32 by the United Kingdom, 21 by China, and 18 by France.

Even seemingly straightforward matters, such as the admission of new members, can become mired in contention as the Soviet Union adroitly demonstrated early in the Cold War and as the United States demonstrates today in blocking Palestinian membership. Beyond this, the impact of the veto is likely worse than we can see. Its looming presence ensures that many resolutions are killed behind closed doors in private conversation, as those drafting the documents are quietly informed that their resolutions will be vetoed.

Previous reform initiatives have attempted to tackle the veto problem. The French-Mexican proposal, first advanced in 2013, called for permanent members to voluntarily suspend their veto in cases of mass atrocities. The Accountability, Coherence, and Transparency Group later advanced a code of conduct, now supported by more than 120 states, which urges P5 states to refrain from using their vetoes in situations of genocide, crimes against humanity, or war crimes.

But a more substantial fix is required. To solve the problems created by the unilateral veto, we must weaken it by instituting a supermajority override. Under this proposal, if over two-thirds of the expanded Security Council, that is to say 15 of its members, and two-thirds of the General Assembly voted to override the veto of a single P5 member, the resolution in question would pass.

After all, if two-thirds of both bodies can agree to override a single P5 member veto, it clearly represents a broad international consensus. A singular P5 member should not be able to block a UNSC resolution passed by all other permanent members, two-thirds of the other 16 permanent associate members, and two-thirds of the 193 members in the General Assembly.

This new proposal would benefit countries in the Global South that previously were unable to meaningfully take part in international rulemaking and security due to inviolable vetoes from above. At the same time, there is no reason for existing P5 members to fear the consequences of this reform. The P5 would still be able to

impose a binding veto on any resolution so long as at least two members were in agreement. This would offer some reassurance, even as it prevents a single power from derailing collective action and raised the political cost of casting a veto in the first place.

This simple change would have immediate ramifications. From Yemen to Gaza, it would open the door to resolving conflicts that have gone from ugly to horrific. The removal of the unilateral veto would break down the barrier that has all too often kept UN peacekeepers and relief efforts from addressing some of the worst tragedies in history.

Reforming the UN would signal a renewed commitment to the founding ideals of the United Nations—peace, cooperation, justice, human rights, and shared responsibility. The result would be a Security Council better suited for the present and better prepared for the future.

Transformation and Opportunities in the Multipolar Era: Regional Integration, Global Governance, and China's Historical Wisdom²

At the edge of a new, multipolar world, we stand at a crossroads of evolution and division. While some countries would like to divide the world into camps, China's historically based long-term vision is one of integrated evolution that benefits all nations.

The world today is undergoing profound transformation. The once dominant unipolar order, US hyperpower, has gradually given way to a more complex and diverse multipolar landscape. While China has long been an advocate of multilateralism, its presence is now no longer deniable. At the Munich Security Conference, it was the central topic of discussion and was treated effectively as already a truism.³ Furthermore new blocs are rising, regionalism is resurging, and independent actors are asserting their autonomy. Traditional patterns of influence are being replaced by new forms of cooperation and competition. Amid this sweeping change, understanding the motivations and dynamics behind these shifts—especially how countries like China are likely to respond, drawing on their deep historical and cultural legacy—has become essential to grasping the future of international relations.

This evolving global landscape is still neck deep in the throes of globalization. Even as the star of economic liberalism seems to be under threat and liberal internationalism in retreat, the processes of regional integration and cooperation across multiple continents have only accelerated, signaling a decisive move away from centralized power toward a more distributed and interconnected world order. This is the core of Globalization 3.0, in that even as economic globalization slows at the broadest scope, all the forces undergirding globalization have remained in play and adjusted to this new post-hegemonic order.

And now that the movement toward multipolarity is unmistakable, with power and influence no longer concentrated in a single superpower or locked in bipolar rivalry, we are seeing a world of greater freedom of action, for better and worse. The dispersion of power across multiple centers and programs of regional integration as a reaction stands out as one of the most vivid expressions of this shift.

In North America, the United States has embarked on an effort to build its own pole, first under the Biden administration, when it tried to retrench itself in its traditional alliance structures and build a united front against the rising power of China, with assemblages such as the Quad and AUKUS as well as increasing NATO involvement in the Pacific. But amidst the second Trump administration, the United States has changed course, embarking on a more narrowly focused North American pole, attempting to coerce Canada, and Belgium via Greenland, to pursue closer relations, while threatening to reassert control over the Panama Canal. These moves reflect a

² This has been adapted from a Background Paper prepared for Trilogue Salzburg held in August 2025.

³ <https://securityconference.org/en/publications/munich-security-report-2025/executive-summary/>.

changing world and a determination to solidify a more modest pole amid intensifying global competition.

Meanwhile, Europe is accelerating its integration process and investing in military capacity and cooperation. Emerging from its post-Brexit slowdown, the European Union, which has since its inception expanded from six founding members to 27, now looks to continue with countries like Ukraine and Moldova as official candidates, signaling continued interest in external growth. Meanwhile, internally, economic integration, with the expansion of the EU's single market, the Eurozone and the Schengen Area, continues. Taken together, these facilitate the free movement of goods, capital, services, and people, and have seen member states cede rights and limited sovereignty by entrusting the supranational EU with greater authority, on topics ranging from the negotiation of trade deals to regulations on food production. Meanwhile, military spending within NATO is soon to rise to 4.5% of GDP across the Alliance, mostly impacting Western European members by signaling the end of their peace dividend and of Europe as a disarmed continent. Despite challenges from populism and political extremism, the EU remains committed to pressing forward with a dual-track approach of deepening and widening integration, while investing in the assets needed to act independently of the US security guarantee.

Beyond Europe and North America, the rise of the Global South has catalyzed the decentralization of power within the international system and demonstrated another path forward. The 2008 global financial crisis propelled emerging economies into global governance and led directly to the creation of the G20 Leaders' Summit—forming the basis of a new framework for cooperation on economic and global issues. Emerging economies hold 11 seats within the G20, and the African Union's inclusion at the 2023 New Delhi summit further amplifies the Global South's voice. BRICS countries stand as prominent representatives of this new wave and have become key drivers of the multipolar evolution. In 2022, measured by purchasing power parity, the BRICS nations accounted for 31.5% of the world economy—surpassing the G7's 30.7%.⁴ This gap is only likely to widen as opportunities for developing economies outpace those of developed ones.

At the same time, Asia is witnessing a surge in regional cooperation. High-profile summits involving China, ASEAN, and the Gulf Cooperation Council have underscored efforts to enhance economic connectivity, energy collaboration, and diplomatic dialogue—reflecting a growing recognition of the importance of regional solidarity in navigating global uncertainties.

Within Southeast Asia, the “ASEAN-X” mechanism exemplifies a pragmatic and flexible approach to regional integration. By allowing differentiated and phased implementation of commitments, ASEAN advances regional unity while respecting member states' sovereignty and diversity. Simultaneously, Southeast Asia is actively deepening cooperation with external powers and international partners, enhancing its strategic connectivity and influence in global governance. ASEAN's own dual

⁴ People's Daily Online, “Let World Hear More BRICS Voices, Witness Greater BRICS Contributions”, August 22, 2023. <https://en.people.cn/n3/2023/0822/c90000-20061840.html> (retrieved July 15, 2025).

approach—strengthening internal cohesion and expanding external partnerships—reflects the broader trend also seen in Europe of intensified regional cooperation under multipolarity. It positions Southeast Asia not only as a cohesive regional bloc but also as a dynamic actor contributing to the construction of a balanced, multipolar international order.⁵

Similarly, Latin America is actively pursuing regional integration as a strategic response to external pressures and internal challenges. The 27th São Paulo Forum, convened in Tegucigalpa, Honduras, gathered over 1000 representatives from more than 400 political parties, organizations, and social movements across Latin America, the Caribbean, and 21 countries worldwide. Under the theme of regional integration, the forum critically examined challenges posed by US and NATO hegemonic actions, the rise of right-wing forces and ongoing global crises that undermine regional unity. In response, it emphasized the necessity of strengthening solidarity and cooperation among left-wing parties to advance pluralistic and inclusive regional integration. Rejecting neoliberalism, neocolonialism, and exclusionary trade agreements, the forum advocated resistance against imperialist interference and unconventional warfare.⁶ Through comprehensive development plans and political unity, Latin America demonstrates a clear commitment to enhancing regional cohesion and collective empowerment.

Across Latin America, Africa, India, and all the nations of the broader Global South, there has been an increasing latitude and tendency to pursue independent foreign policies. This impulse is comingled with a refusal to align strictly with any major power bloc, with non-alignment reflecting a desire for greater autonomy and diversified partnerships. Meanwhile, liberal internationalism has receded in the United States, and the rise of tensions has hindered the free flow of trade. Yet despite these two factors, the continuing growth of global trade demonstrated another quiet truth: If the state of global trade over the past decades has been a dance, then yes, the dance partners may be changing, and regional dynamics may grow more pronounced. But people are still looking for partners in the waltz. Trade itself remains fundamental to undergirding the prosperity of the present, even as it has become more unpopular in developed nations.

Further, the Global South as a whole seems to thoroughly understand that global challenges, such as climate change, development, and security, require flexible, multi-lateral solutions. Collectively, these trends illustrate that the world is no longer defined by singular or binary power structures. Instead, regional blocs and independent actors together shape a complex new multipolar order characterized by overlapping networks of cooperation, competition, and negotiation.

As alluded to earlier, during the Biden administration, attempts were made to revive a Cold War style ideological approach, building coalitions of “like-minded”

⁵ Dai Yi and Lai Zhengshi, “Institutional Changes of ‘ASEAN-X’ and Regional Integration in Southeast Asia”, *Southeast Asian Studies* 1: 49–62, <https://doi.org/10.19561/j.cnki.sas.2025.01.049>.

⁶ Wang Ximan and Hu Jiahui, “An Analysis of the 27th São Paulo Forum Meeting”, *Contemporary World and Socialism (Bimonthly)*, no. 1: 170–190, <https://doi.org/10.16502/j.cnki.11-3404/d.2025.01.017>.

countries to counter China. Initiatives like AUKUS and the Quad brought in new partners such as India and framed the issue as a struggle between democracy and authoritarianism to preserve the “free world.” However, with changes in US leadership and shifting geopolitical realities, these ideological divisions have rapidly fallen by the wayside and China’s relations with countries previously aligned against it have begun to improve.⁷ This shift highlights a defining feature of the emerging multipolar order: The world is no longer shaped by rigid ideological blocs, but by a flexible, overlapping web of pragmatic regional groupings.

If disruption is a rupture—a sudden break where conditions on the ground are exposed as having rested on false assumptions, as with the collapse of the Soviet Union and the end of the bipolar order—then evolution is when leaders and stakeholders recognize change early and understand its implications.

We have already cleared the first hurdle: We have seen the change coming. Just as thinkers like John Robert Seeley foresaw that Britain’s era of global hegemony would not last as “nations organized on a vaster scale,” we today stand at the threshold of a new multipolar era. Fundamental shifts in the world’s economic organization are already under way, signaling the slow but inexorable end of American hegemonic power. China’s response to this oncoming global change and the solution it offers is deeply rooted in its millennia-old history and rich cultural traditions, which imbue the country with a distinctive sense of confidence and composure. Over thousands of years, through the rise and fall of dynasties, through the birth of the modern Chinese state, the Chinese people have cultivated a broad historical perspective, one that allows engagement with today’s international challenges as transient episodes within the vast continuum of time. A long-term view fosters a mindset of patience and careful deliberation, encouraging thoughtful responses rather than impulsive reactions. By understanding that crises and upheavals are often temporary, China is approaching global uncertainties with a calm prudence, always seeking the right timing and approach to navigate change effectively.

This long perspective is complemented by China’s heritage, which has instilled a strong sense of pragmatism and stability in the national character. For centuries, self-sufficiency in agriculture shaped a collective mentality centered around “having enough to eat, no need to panic.” Even when external circumstances become turbulent or threatening, the worst-case scenario requires a calm focus inward on sustaining the nation. This has freed China from the need to respond aggressively or make hasty compromises under pressure. With the exception of the Mongol invasions of Japan, which were birthed of a young foreign dynasty in control of the Chinese mainland, China has always calmly set its own pace and strategic direction: avoiding starting wars, and instead maintaining stability even amid instability.

However, this pragmatic approach should not be mistaken for conservatism or isolationism. History shows that China has often turned periods of turmoil into opportunities for transformation and growth. Many of its greatest leaders and founding

⁷ Robert A. Manning and Mathew Burrows, “Biden’s Foreign Policy Legacy: A Troubled Interregnum”, The Henry L. Stimson Center, November 19, 2024. <https://www.stimson.org/2024/bidens-foreign-policy-legacy/>.

emperors emerged in times of chaos, seizing moments of uncertainty to establish new orders and reshape the nation. Meanwhile, it was the complacency and hegemonic breakout of the Qing dynasty that led to the great divergence in both military and technology that in part led to China's weakness in the nineteenth and early twentieth century. This historical experience nurtures a mindset in which change itself is not something to be feared; rather, it is a natural and inevitable part of life that must be understood and harnessed. Change represents opportunity and what truly matters is the ability to recognize emerging trends, set clear objectives, and adapt flexibly to evolving circumstances.

Consequently, China's strategic approach today is anchored in having well-defined long-term goals while maintaining flexibility in how to achieve them. It embraces a pragmatic attitude that any method or path contributing to these goals is worth pursuing, without rigid adherence to fixed formulas or ideologies. In the complex and shifting landscape of international relations, China not only seeks to protect its own national interests but also aims to play a constructive role in global governance.

China's success reinforces this message. China proves that peaceful nations can both benefit from economic globalization and deftly sails against the headwinds facing our current era, offering compromise, peace, and mutual benefit for all.

For example, in crises such as the conflicts in Ukraine or the Middle East, China consistently maintains an independent and balanced stance, actively engaging in diplomatic mediation efforts to promote peace and stability. This reflects an understanding that global disorder can also create openings for constructive influence, and that success depends on seizing the right moments to shape outcomes beneficially for both China and the wider world.

Reflecting on the tumultuous history of the last century, China's journey offers valuable lessons. During periods of national crisis and decline, the Chinese people engaged in tireless experimentation with various social, political, and economic models in search of a viable path forward. The country became a vast laboratory where multiple governance systems—from parliamentary democracies to presidential regimes—were tested. Many of these efforts faced significant challenges due to incompatibilities with China's unique cultural and historical context.

Through intense competition among these different ideas and real-world trials, the People's Republic of China as it exists today gradually took shape. This historical process underscores a simple but important truth: Sustainable solutions arise only from pragmatic approaches tailored to a nation's specific circumstances and realities. Since the founding of the PRC, this principle of pragmatism has guided many of China's most pivotal decisions—from the historic normalization of relations with the United States to the launch of the reform and opening-up policies that propelled China's rapid modernization. Had China chosen alternative paths, the country and indeed the world today would look very different.

And now China offers its own solution to all who would listen: a peaceful and empowering evolution, rather than a hard rupture of disruption—through the five principles first articulated at the Bandung Conference in 1954: mutual respect for sovereignty, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and

peaceful coexistence. China is offering itself up, engaging economically and peacefully with every continent, looking toward the mutual benefit born of trade, trust and capacity building that can glue us all together in an evolution, not a revolution, to bring the world together and make it a better place. From the China-CELAC forum in Latin America to the China-FOCAC forum in Africa, from the ASEAN-X models to the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP), China is committed to this path.

In sum, the world stands at a crossroads of evolution and disruption. The trend toward multipolarity and regional integration marks a clear break from the colonial era's spheres of influence and the rigid bipolarity of the Cold War. Today's world is shaped by voluntary cooperation among sovereign states, overlapping, inclusive regional frameworks, and pragmatic, flexible strategies rooted in each nation's history and culture. China's approach—anchored to long-term goals while adapting with flexibility—exemplifies how historical wisdom and practical experience can provide stability and opportunity amid uncertainty. As global power continues to diffuse and regional networks grow more complex, the ability to adapt, cooperate, and maintain clarity of purpose will be essential to navigating the challenges and opportunities of the multipolar age.

China-Led SCO Is a Critical Salve for the Ailments of the Global Order⁸

As the world faces fragmentation and interstate conflict that has not been seen in decades, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation is working to drive practical solutions. Neither it nor BRICS seek to replace the United Nations, but amid UN paralysis, organizations that champion regional multilateralism can help sustain global order.

Eighty years after World War II ended, the multilateral system is faltering. The United Nations, once the symbol of post-war peace and cooperation, is increasingly sidelined by unilateral actions and trade wars, amid the marginalization of the Global South in decision-making.

We are at risk of a world where tariffs and sanctions replace negotiation, conflicts multiply, and the very principles of international law are often ignored. If the international community is to avoid drifting further into fragmentation, new governance approaches are urgently needed.

It is in this moment of turbulence that the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) gathered in Tianjin, China, for its largest summit ever, underscoring its growing role as a forum for stability, dialogue, and development across Eurasia.

What began over two decades ago as a regional body to manage border security has evolved into a comprehensive institution with economic, cultural, and, increasingly, global faces. The summit delivered not only political dialogue but also set forth new mechanisms of cooperation, including a SCO development bank.

Chinese President Xi Jinping also unveiled his Global Governance Initiative, the latest of proposals that include the Belt and Road Initiative, Global Development Initiative, Global Security Initiative, and Global Civilisation Initiative. The new framework sets out five guiding principles: sovereign equality, adherence to the international rule of law, support for multilateralism under the UN system, people-centered development, and action-oriented cooperation. The SCO embodies the five principles, providing a platform for countries of different cultures, ideologies, and political systems to cooperate. It is a critical salve for the ailments of today's global system, in which some states raise tariffs and undermine global institutions, while others call for reform but fail to deliver.

Economic and trade issues stood out in Tianjin. Amid mounting protectionism, the SCO committed to keeping regional markets open and inclusive. Europe has moved to tighten rules on imported vehicles and the United States continues to rely on tariffs and sanctions as tools of leverage, but China has gone in the opposite direction. It is removing its tariffs for 53 African countries, opening its market to some of the world's poorest nations.

The message is simple: as globalization looks to be retreating, there are still major powers willing to promote openness and inclusion. For SCO members and their partners, that example provides confidence that there is a cooperative path forward.

⁸ First published on September 12, 2025 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

Just as important, the summit placed digital cooperation and green transition at the heart of its agenda. Across the SCO, local champions from fintech to e-commerce are reshaping economies, while China is providing infrastructure, training, and technological expertise. Projects linking renewable energy to computing capacity, as in Xinjiang, offer models of how to combine resource endowments with sustainable innovation.

SCO member states also pledged to expand scholarships, scientific exchanges, and joint research programs, investing in the human capital needed for the next development phase. These steps reflect the action-oriented spirit China emphasized, turning rhetoric about cooperation into measurable outcomes.

But the SCO is not only about economics. In a world where interstate war has returned on a scale unseen in decades, the organization's convening power is itself a public good. The Tianjin summit saw the leaders of China, India, and Pakistan at the same table—a rare moment given historical tensions in South Asia. Such encounters do not resolve disputes overnight, but they build the habits of dialogue and trust that are indispensable for peace.

Similarly, the SCO provides a forum where discussions on Ukraine, Gaza, and other conflicts can take place without the ideological divisions that often paralyze other bodies. Its capacity to bring diverse actors together, including states with different political systems and security concerns, is becoming an important counterweight to the polarization dominating global affairs.

The SCO is no replacement for the UN, nor does it seek to be. But as the UN grapples with paralysis, regional multilateralism has a growing role to play in sustaining global order. Alongside BRICS, which has expanded its outreach to Africa and Latin America, the SCO shows how the Global South can organize, articulate its interests, and create institutions. Neither of these organizations reject the current global system; rather, they seek to reinforce the principles of the UN Charter through practical initiatives.

China's role in this evolution is central. As the world's second-largest economy, it has both the responsibility and resources to support multilateral efforts. By cutting tariffs, financing infrastructure, sharing technology, and convening dialogue, it shows leadership is not only about military power or diplomatic rhetoric, but also ability to generate benefits and confidence. Whether through the Belt and Road Initiative, development banks, or SCO projects in energy and digital transformation, China shows multilateralism can be revitalized through deeds.

The world is in danger of drifting into disorder. Conflicts are rising, global trade rules are under strain, and the legitimacy of international institutions is being questioned. But the lesson of Tianjin is that alternatives exist. By broadening its mission, launching institutions, and embracing inclusiveness, the SCO shows it can be a pillar of multipolar stability. The Global Governance Initiative's framework provides a philosophical compass, while the SCO and BRICS supply the practical means to steer through turbulence.

If the post-war multilateral system is to be repaired, vision and action are required. The SCO's evolution suggests that even in an era of fragmentation, models of cooperation are emerging. For the over 3 billion people of its member states and the wider international community, this is an unalloyed good.

Only a Multipolar Coalition Can Secure Ukraine Peace⁹

To move forward, negotiations must be conducted on the basis of security guarantees that reflect today's geopolitical realities.

The now-delayed meeting between US President Donald Trump and his Russian counterpart Vladimir Putin in Budapest, Hungary, could have been a turning point toward peace in Ukraine. Instead, it has revealed a deeper fault line.

However, it is one that can be overcome. Even the Kremlin's special envoy for investment and economic cooperation, Kirill Dmitriev, believes that the parties are close to ending the war.

The global community should offer an offramp and seek a middle ground amenable to both sides. No ceasefire, however well-meaning, will work unless it factors in the deeper struggles around Europe's security posture and Russia's anxieties about the West. In short, what is needed is credible enforcement and balanced security guarantees.

In this regard, Kyiv rightly demands protection from future aggression. Meanwhile, Moscow insists on assurances that NATO the transatlantic security alliance, will not creep closer to its border. The fact that the Budapest summit was even on the table indicates that both sides are, at least ostensibly, open to "freezing" the conflict. However, trust is running thin.

I have previously argued for the creation of a formal seven-party talks framework, reminiscent of the Korean six-party talks, comprising the UN Security Council's five permanent members—the United States, France, Britain, China, and Russia—plus Ukraine and representatives of the European Union. But now, an older precedent can offer guidance: the Korean Armistice Agreement of 1953 did not end the war, but it greatly reduced the violence.

Such an approach, if enacted with the help of neutral third-party oversight, could offer a viable path outside maximalist goals. If Ukraine and Russia are serious about halting the fighting, they will need to embrace a peacekeeping framework strong enough to deter violations but neutral enough to be accepted by both.

Such a force cannot come solely from NATO or Russia. It must draw legitimacy from a broader international coalition that reflects today's multipolar reality. The UN is an indispensable vessel for establishing such a presence, but any peace-building efforts must be strengthened by the involvement of BRICS countries that have maintained dialogue with Russia and Ukraine.

Troops or observers from China, India, Brazil, or South Africa deployed alongside European partners such as Germany, France, Italy, Britain, and Poland could support the balanced mission the situation calls for. Their presence would show that the world's major regions share responsibility for security issues and would allay concerns that peacekeepers would not honor their mission.

China can play a constructive role. It is both Russia and Ukraine's largest trading partner and has maintained communication with all sides since the beginning of the

⁹ First published on October 29, 2025 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

war. Beijing's 12-point peace proposal emphasized sovereignty, humanitarian access, and the avoidance of nuclear escalation, principles that remain valid.

More recently, China has expanded its cooperation with BRICS and called for inclusive diplomacy to address conflict. Acting through the UN and in coordination with BRICS, China can serve as a guarantor of peace and peacekeeper, helping design a neutral framework that bridges the security fears of each camp.

The delayed Budapest talks should not be read as the end of diplomacy, but as a chance to begin a more realistic process. Should talks proceed, a wider table might be found at the coming Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation summit in Gyeongju, South Korea, this week. President Xi Jinping, Trump and a Russian delegation are expected to be there, as are leaders from across the Asia-Pacific, a region known for both conflict and reconciliation.

On the sidelines, an informal trilateral meeting could be convened to explore the outlines of a "Gyeongju Ceasefire Initiative," paving the way for a formal peace conference under UN auspices that includes the organization's Security Council, Ukraine, and the EU.

For Washington and Moscow, this would provide a dignified exit from confrontation. For Kyiv, it would offer concrete protection and a pathway to reconstruction. For Europe, it would reduce the strain of endless crisis management. And for the Global South, it would mark a long-overdue moment when emerging powers help shoulder the burdens of peace.

A carefully crafted freeze in hostilities could unlock humanitarian corridors, stabilize food and energy supplies, and help kick-start Ukraine's recovery, a task that will require the industrial and financial capacities of both the West and Asia.

Some may dismiss this lofty proposal as idealistic, but the same might have been said of Germany and France being in the same political union or the Korean Armistice Agreement being mostly maintained over the years. Peace doesn't have to come from mutual affection. It can grow from managed coexistence.

The delay of the Trump-Putin summit was not rooted in personal mistrust but rather in the absence of the right frameworks to monitor and support badly needed security guarantees. That gap can and must be filled by the wider international community.

The war in Ukraine has reshaped global politics and strained institutions that were designed for another era. If the UN and BRICS can forge a credible peacekeeping framework that freezes violence while enabling negotiations, the outcome would not only save Ukrainian lives but also show that global cooperation can triumph over great power competition.

A truce enforced by shared responsibility is better than a victory won with exhaustion and needlessly filled graves. Diplomacy without design cannot endure. The world should seize the moment before it slips away. In Gyeongju, the United States, Russia, China, and other partners have a chance to chart a path away from attrition and toward stability.

The Outlook for Multilateralism Under the Shadow of Protectionism¹⁰

Advancing economic integration and cooperation among Asian nations can help to spur a broader movement toward multilateralism and drive global recovery and institutional reform in a direction that is more equitable.

As we enter 2025, the rise of unilateralism and protectionism has dealt fresh blows to global stability and economic recovery. The global economy's challenges and uncertainties are mounting, fueling growing concern and anxiety within the international community. Against this shifting global backdrop, how to advance economic globalization and uphold multilateralism has become a pressing issue for Asian countries. Around the world, trade barriers, economic sanctions, tariffs, and other protectionist measures have hindered cross-border economic cooperation and restrained global growth. In such a context, how Asian countries can take on a more proactive role in driving global economic recovery and stability, particularly in promoting sustainable development and economic integration, has become a key issue in the current global economic landscape.

As the global economic environment continues to evolve, Asian countries' strategic importance is increasing. The ongoing Boao Forum for Asia Annual Report on Asia's Economic Outlook highlights how Asian countries like China are taking the lead globally in growth promotion, green development, energy transition, and innovation, especially in cutting-edge technologies like artificial intelligence. This shift has not only spurred regional economic expansion in Asia but also injected strong momentum and vast potential into the sustainable development of the global economy.

Yet the global trade landscape is being reshaped by the rise of protectionist policies, most notably those stemming from US unilateralism and protectionism. Prolonged trade wars, escalating tariffs, and tightening economic restrictions have posed severe challenges to both China and the broader global economy.

Despite mounting external pressure, China has responded with a measured and strategic approach by prioritizing market openness and diversification of trade partnerships. China has demonstrated resilience amid a turbulent global trade environment through tax cuts and by granting tariff exemptions to over 40 of the world's least developed countries (LDCs).

One telling indicator of this shift is the declining role of the United States in China's overall trade portfolio: the United States now accounts for just 11% of China's total imports and exports, down about 10% from a peak of 21.5% in 2002. Although the United States has imposed steep tariffs on Chinese goods, the protectionist measures spearheaded by the Trump administration have ultimately failed to suppress the growth of bilateral trade. In fact, despite tariff pressures, the total volume of China-US trade has risen from \$500 billion to over \$600 billion, marking about a 20% increase.

¹⁰ First published on March 27, 2025 by CGTN and revised for this collection.

In addressing global economic challenges, China has responded with restraint and strategic precision rather than resorting to sweeping retaliatory measures. For instance, China opted for targeted countermeasures on roughly 100 specific product categories instead of launching all-out trade retaliation. This calibrated response reflects a fundamental economic truth: in a trade war, there are no winners.

In this context, the pursuit of Asian integration takes on heightened significance. As one of the primary engines of global economic growth, China should work proactively to deepen cooperation with its regional neighbors, including the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), India, South Korea, and Japan, to lay the groundwork for a broader Asian alliance. Beyond economics, Asia also possesses unique cultural elements that can serve as powerful bonds of unity. Shared traditions, such as Confucian values and the symbolic “chopstick culture,” reflect common philosophical roots and lifestyles that can help foster a stronger sense of regional solidarity. Over time, this envisioned Asian alliance could encompass Central Asia, South Asia, the Gulf region, and even parts of the Pacific Rim, contributing to global economic integration.

In addition to regional integration, establishing cooperative mechanisms like the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership (CPTPP) is equally vital. Through multilateral cooperation, Asia can forge greater resilience and unleash more innovative potential, accelerating regional economic integration while supporting the broader recovery and development of the global economy. The CPTPP is not just a supplement to the international free trade system; it is a significant force driving Asia’s own integration and advancing globalization more broadly. Over the coming years, Asia’s economic potential is expected to expand substantially, particularly in emerging sectors such as intelligent manufacturing, green development, and the digital economy.

As a major player in global trade, China should deepen cooperation with the European Union, Australia, and Latin American countries to help shape a more open, fair, and inclusive global trade system. The World Trade Organization (WTO) remains the central governing body of international trade, and preserving its authority is essential to ensuring that global commerce continues to operate within a rules-based framework. China has consistently advocated for WTO reform and multilateral trade agreements recently. In September 2024, during the WTO Public Forum, the Center for China and Globalization (CCG) hosted a seminar at WTO Headquarters in Geneva, emphasizing the importance of advancing trade liberalization. The event urged global economies to take initiative in pushing trade reform, rather than passively waiting for the United States to re-engage in the multilateral system.

In conclusion, under the growing shadow of protectionism, Asian countries must remain committed to multilateralism, advance their efforts to enhance regional cooperation, and assume greater global responsibility. By advancing integration within Asia and deepening cooperation with other global economies, the region is poised to become an important engine of global growth. It will play an increasingly central role in shaping the world economy. The current challenges and uncertainties are a test of resilience and a critical opportunity to drive economic recovery and long-term development. Asian countries should take on a more proactive role in this process, working together to help steer the global economy toward a more stable, prosperous, and sustainable future.

Toward a More Multipolar World: Sino-US-Europe Dynamics in the Trump 2.0 Era¹¹

The return of Donald Trump to the White House also marks a return to “America First” policymaking, putting Europe in a difficult position, sowing division in the transatlantic relationship. An intended but positive consequence however is Europe’s newfound ability to act as a balancing pole.

On April 2, 2025, the United States imposed a 10% baseline tariff on all imports, alongside sharply higher rates on goods from around 60 countries—34% on China, 25% on South Korea, and 20% on the European Union. Shortly thereafter, President Trump further raised tariffs on Chinese products to an unprecedented 145%. This new wave of protectionism, amid intensifying geopolitical tensions, is set to reshape the dynamics of US-China-Europe relations. Even Europe—long a close ally of the United States—is feeling the strain, as trust in multilateral cooperation erodes under growing policy fragmentation and market volatility.

Against the backdrop of a complex and rapidly changing global landscape, the Trump administration’s policies are set to lead to significant adjustments in Sino-US-Europe relations, bringing both opportunities and challenges. These adjustments are manifesting in several ways: (1) China and the United States will seek to preserve stable relations despite ongoing turbulence, (2) the transatlantic alliance between the United States and Europe will face pressure, and (3) China and Europe have some cooperative space in dealing with Trump’s policies. Overall, China, the United States, and the EU are heading toward a more multipolar relationship.

Sino-American Relations: Seeking Balance amid Turbulence

Trump’s policies remain unpredictable, yet his transactional and business-oriented approach is evident. Under his administration, US-China relations will inevitably struggle to find balance amid ongoing turbulence.

Tariff Policy: A Key Focus of Trump’s Trade Relations with China

The Trump administration remains fixated on bilateral goods deficits as a measure of national decline, but this view ignores the basic structure of the US economy. In 2024, the United States recorded a services trade surplus of \$300 billion¹² and this discounts contributions by local branches of US multinationals abroad. Moreover, advantages like the dollar’s seigniorage, overseas investment returns, and its unmatched capacity to attract global talent—with 60% of Nobel laureates working in the United States and

¹¹ First published on May 15, 2025 by *Limes* and revised for this collection.

¹² United States Congress Joint Economic Committee, Trade Update, May 2025.

47% of American AI talent originating from China¹³—reflect its privileged position in the international system.

The privileged position of the United States doesn't end there. The revenue of US-owned enterprises in China significantly exceeded that of Chinese-owned enterprises in the United States by \$400 billion.¹⁴ 80% of Apple phones are made in China and count as Chinese exports,¹⁵ but the money is made by Apple, a US company that designs and marksup the completed iPhone and its digital ecosystem.

Far from being a victim of globalization, the United States has been one of its greatest beneficiaries. In truth, the only area where the United States runs a consistent trade deficit is in goods manufacturing—and this was never an accident. America made a deliberate and calculated shift toward a service-driven, high-tech economy. It moved away from low-margin, labor-intensive, and often polluting industries toward sectors that are cleaner, more profitable, and globally dominant. The United States is leading the world in education, technology, biosciences, the digital economy, and AI. The United States cannot simply play a “winner takes all” game where it dominates even labor-intensive industries that it previously abandoned. To now treat this shift as a failure is to rewrite decades of economic policy.

Although China and the United States have recently resumed negotiations—and President Trump has signaled a possible reduction in tariffs—trade barriers are likely to remain a central issue in bilateral relations for the foreseeable future.

Potential for Chinese Investment in the United States

Trump has been relatively open to Chinese investment in the United States and may use it to boost domestic manufacturing. While Trump aims to block Chinese car imports, he has also expressed willingness to support Chinese automakers setting up manufacturing operations in the United States. During the previous trade war, many Chinese companies established factories in Mexico to circumvent tariffs. If the United States adopts policies encouraging Chinese enterprises to invest and set up factories domestically in the United States, this could open new avenues for Sino-US economic cooperation. Success stories like Fuyao Glass and CATL's investment talks with American firms highlight the feasibility of such a model.

Additionally, Trump may look at repealing portions of the Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act, CHIPS and Science Act, and the Inflation Reduction Act passed by the Biden administration. He may redirect unused funds to traditional infrastructure projects, contrasting with the more restrictive approach taken by the Biden administration toward Chinese investment.

¹³ Ma Yingyi, “US security and immigration policies threaten its AI leadership,” Brookings, April 4, 2024.

¹⁴ Zhao Huanxin, “Envoy: China doesn't want or fear trade war,” chinadaily.com.cn, May 5, 2025.

¹⁵ Andy Hirschfeld, “Apple to move assembly of US phones to India in shift away from China,” Al Jazeera, April 25, 2025.

Space for Negotiation: Trump's "Peace President" Promise

In the geopolitical arena, Trump has pledged to be a "peace president." Trump's plan, which bars Ukraine from joining NATO and relies on European forces to keep the peace, faces widespread skepticism. With Russian President Vladimir Putin likely to resist a Western-led peacekeeping force, the Trump administration has shifted the dynamics: no US troops, relying instead on contributions from Europe and potentially elsewhere. Given China's diplomatic ties with Russia and several Middle Eastern countries, it is likely that Trump will seek Beijing's cooperation in addressing these issues.

China's active role in Middle Eastern diplomacy, such as brokering a deal between Saudi Arabia and Iran and hosting meetings with Palestinian factions, reflects its growing influence in the region. Having contributed more UN peacekeepers in recent years than any other permanent UN Security Council member, China could spearhead a neutral force, possibly alongside India and Brazil.

On the Korean Peninsula, Trump previously sought China's assistance in addressing North Korea's nuclear challenges. Although his efforts were unsuccessful in his first term, the situation on the Peninsula has escalated, with tensions between North and South Korea approaching a crisis. To fulfill his promise of being a "peace president," Trump may again seek China's help.

Trump's Pragmatic Approach to Taiwan

Trump's approach to Taiwan has been more pragmatic compared to other administrations. He may seek to maintain a dynamic balance with China on Taiwan, avoiding further escalation of tensions in the Taiwan Strait. This contrasts with the Biden administration, which strengthened military and political ties with Taiwan, undermining the "One China" policy and escalating risks to regional stability.

Some US experts have recommended reaffirming the "One China" policy, and Trump may choose to do so, potentially exploring new measures to strengthen this commitment. Negotiating a new joint communiqué could be a step toward better managing Taiwan-related tensions, such as ceasing arms sales to Taiwan and opposing "Taiwan independence."

Transatlantic Relations: Shifting Dynamics

During the Biden administration, Europe followed the United States on many issues, resulting in relatively stable US-EU relations. However, Trump's "America First" policies and his return to power could deeply impact the US-EU relationship.

Trade Relations Under Threat

Trump's tariff war is likely to trigger global trade tensions, disrupt the stability of global supply chains, and lead to a sharp deterioration in the international trade environment. This will undoubtedly be a severe blow to Europe's economy, which is highly dependent on foreign trade.

According to data from the EU Statistical Office, in 2023, the total value of goods exported from the EU to the United States reached 502 billion euros, while imports from the United States totaled 344 billion euros, resulting in a trade surplus of 158 billion euros. The United States is the EU's largest destination for goods exports, accounting for 19.7% of total EU exports; it is also the EU's second-largest source of goods imports (after China), accounting for 13.7% of total EU imports.¹⁶

This data shows that the United States is the EU's largest export market. An increase in tariffs will cause European goods to become significantly more expensive in the United States, weakening their market competitiveness and affecting the already struggling EU economy. Jan Hatzius, Chief Economist at Goldman Sachs, stated that if a transatlantic tariff war breaks out, the EU will suffer greater losses than the United States. The tariff war is expected to reduce the EU's GDP by 1%.¹⁷ According to Germany's Ifo Institute for Economic Research, the tariff war could lead to a 14.9% decline in Germany's exports to the United States.¹⁸

Security Concerns

European security will face serious challenges. NATO is the cornerstone of European security, the bond that maintains the transatlantic relationship, and also a tool for US control over Europe. The United States not only has 100,000 troops stationed in Europe and tactical nuclear weapons deployed, it also possesses a large network of military bases on the continent. Germany's Stuttgart military base hosts the United States. European Command and the US Africa Command, while Italy's Naples naval base is the headquarters of the US Sixth Fleet. Recently, following Romania, the United States has deployed a land-based "Aegis" missile defense system in Poland.

During the "Trump 1.0 era," the US government withdrew from the Intermediate-Range Nuclear Forces Treaty and the Open Skies Treaty, reduced the number of US troops stationed in Germany, and explicitly demanded that its allies increase defense spending, even threatening to withdraw from NATO, which severely impacted European security. With Trump's strong return to power, he has made it clear that NATO allies must increase defense spending to 5% of GDP and questioned the high financial contributions of the United States to NATO.

¹⁶ Zhang Linchu, "The Impact of Trump's Election on EU-US Relations and Sino-European Relations", cfisnet, November 18, 2024.

¹⁷ Chartered Institute of Export and International Trade, "What could the new Donald Trump presidency mean for trade?" November 6, 2024.

¹⁸ ifo, "Germany's US exports could fall by 14.9% if Trump is re-elected", September 23, 2024.

If the Trump administration ultimately adopts these policies, it will deal a significant blow to European security strategy. Europe will not only need to increase military spending but also assume more security responsibilities, which will further strain Europe's financial burden. Reports indicate that by 2024, defense spending in 18 NATO countries will have reached the 2% GDP target, while 14 countries still have not met the NATO-mandated 2% standard. Against the backdrop of economic sluggishness, this is undoubtedly a severe test for the EU.¹⁹

The Russia-Ukraine War: A Major Test for US-EU Relations

The Russia-Ukraine war serves as a litmus test for transatlantic relations, but the situation is becoming increasingly complex. For Europe, the Ukraine issue extends beyond regional security, shaping the entire European security architecture. However, significant disagreements between the United States and Europe are inevitable, particularly regarding aid to Ukraine, potential peace negotiations, post-war security structures, and relations with Russia. These differences will have far-reaching consequences for US-EU relations, European security, and the evolving international order. Meanwhile, internal divisions within the EU are also emerging. Economic slowdowns, the energy crisis, and growing public dissatisfaction are leading some EU countries to reconsider their support for Ukraine. As a result, the trajectory of the Russia-Ukraine war will serve as a key indicator of shifting dynamics in transatlantic relations.

Global Governance Challenges

The United States and Europe face numerous challenges in global governance. During the "Trump 1.0 era," Trump adopted a skeptical, resistant, and even destructive attitude toward global governance and multilateral mechanisms. He withdrew from organizations such as UNESCO and the World Health Organization. After his re-election, Trump continued withdrawing from agreements like the Paris Agreement and the UN Human Rights Council, while exploring ways to counterbalance existing multilateral mechanisms by strengthening bilateral relations and small multilateral cooperation.

The EU actively advocates for multilateralism and is committed to strengthening the global governance system by cooperating with international organizations and countries to tackle global challenges together. The EU has always played an active role in addressing climate change, striving to promote global efforts to combat climate change and biodiversity loss. Therefore, the EU and the Trump administration will face numerous challenges and policy differences in global governance, which will seriously impact US-EU relations and undermine America's leadership in transatlantic relations.

¹⁹ NATO, "Secretary General welcomes unprecedented rise in NATO defence spending", February 14, 2024.

Sino-European Relations: New Opportunities Amid Challenges

In recent years, Sino-European relations have developed with mixed outcomes. On the one hand, bilateral relations have shown signs of stabilizing, with frequent high-level exchanges, reflecting a trend in some European countries and the EU to correct their policies toward China and return to a more rational approach. This demonstrates the complementary advantages and mutually beneficial nature of Sino-European cooperation. On the other hand, influenced by the EU's "threefold positioning" toward China and its efforts to "derisk," trade protectionism, the politicization of economic issues, and a general trend toward security and ideological thinking have caused turbulence in Sino-European trade relations. However, if the Trump administration continues with its "America First" and isolationist policies, Sino-European relations may experience a new turning point.

Sino-European Cooperation in Facing the US Trade War

Trump's trade protectionist policies could further deepen Sino-European economic relations, pushing the EU to rely more on the Chinese market for diversifying trade risks and maintaining export growth. For the EU, maintaining stable export markets and diversified trade partners is crucial. As the world's second-largest economy with the most promising consumer market, China will become an "alternative" option for the EU's economic development. Furthermore, the Chinese government has been actively promoting greater openness and continuously optimizing its business environment, offering more attractive investment opportunities for EU enterprises. In 2023, Sino-European trade reached \$783 billion (€847.3 billion), with China being the EU's largest trading partner, while the EU is China's second-largest trading partner.²⁰ Therefore, if Trump were to wage trade and tariff wars against both Europe and China, despite varying intensities, the result would force China and the EU to jointly respond to the US trade and tariff wars.

Sino-European cooperation could be reignited in electric vehicle tariff negotiations, where both sides would strive to manage differences, enhance trust, and reach agreements for mutual benefit. The automotive industry is a key engine for Europe's prosperity, supporting over 13 million direct and indirect jobs and contributing approximately €1 trillion to the EU's GDP.²¹

Currently, the European automotive industry faces multiple challenges, including clean energy transformation, supply chain restructuring, and technological innovation. China's industrial chain advantages in new energy vehicles complement Europe's advanced manufacturing capabilities, presenting a significant opportunity

²⁰ Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Republic of China, "Join Hands to Promote the Healthy and Stable Development of China-EU Relations", November 21, 2024.

²¹ "The European Union Launches Strategic Dialogue on the Automotive Industry and Will Present an Action Plan in March to Address Transformation," Caixin, January 31, 2025.

for cooperation. Existing Sino-European automotive industry partnerships, such as the successful Geely-Volvo collaboration and joint ventures with Volkswagen and BMW in China, demonstrate how both sides can deepen cooperation and address these challenges through complementary strengths. Specific collaboration paths include jointly establishing production bases in Europe to address potential trade barriers and working together to explore emerging markets in Southeast Asia, Latin America, and other regions. The layout of BYD in Europe and CATL's overseas expansion can provide useful references for this cooperation.

Renewing Investment Agreements

The EU-China Comprehensive Agreement on Investment (CAI) has faced significant delays and hurdles due to political tensions and concerns over human rights issues. However, under Trump's isolationist policies, there is a potential opportunity for the revival of this agreement. If this agreement is successfully revived, it could have a profound impact on Sino-European relations, enhancing political, economic, and cultural cooperation. The CAI could provide a framework for addressing disputes while promoting collaboration in critical sectors such as technology, energy, and manufacturing. Both sides stand to benefit from a stronger economic partnership. For China, the agreement would improve its international image and help solidify its position as a responsible global economic player, while also unlocking new avenues for economic integration with Europe. For Europe, the agreement could provide access to China's vast consumer market, investment opportunities, and technological innovations. In addition, the potential for smoother trade relations and investment flows would provide European companies with more favorable conditions to expand their operations within China.

Leading the Green Transition

As the world grapples with the escalating impacts of climate change, both China and Europe are increasingly being called upon to take a leadership role in the global green transition. China, having made significant strides in the development of renewable energy, particularly solar power, is positioned to play a crucial role in the green transition. As the world's largest producer of solar panels and a major player in wind and hydroelectric energy, China's efforts to transition to a low-carbon economy are critical not only for its own long-term development but also for global climate goals. Meanwhile, Europe, with its commitment to green policies such as the European Green Deal, is already on the path to achieving carbon neutrality by 2050. China's collaboration with Europe in advancing green technologies, renewable energy infrastructure, and carbon reduction strategies is essential to achieving the ambitious global climate targets set by the Paris Agreement. By pooling resources and expertise, China and Europe can set a powerful example of international cooperation in the fight against climate change.

Collaborating on Artificial Intelligence (AI)

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is transforming industries and societies across the globe. Both China and Europe are at the forefront of AI development, with China rapidly advancing its AI capabilities in sectors such as e-commerce, autonomous vehicles, and healthcare, and Europe investing heavily in AI research and development, particularly in areas like ethics and regulation. Given the vast potential of AI to revolutionize the global economy, China and Europe must work together to ensure its responsible, equitable, and sustainable development.

The urgency of addressing AI as both an opportunity and a challenge was underscored at the inaugural Global AI Summit in London, where leaders from various countries discussed the future of AI governance. At this year's Global AI Summit in Paris, 61 countries signed a declaration to establish an inclusive and sustainable AI governance mechanism, while both the United States and the United Kingdom refrained from signing it. By collaborating on AI, China and Europe can work together to create robust ethical guidelines, establish fair regulatory frameworks, and advance technological innovations that improve the quality of life for people worldwide.

Upholding Multilateralism

Both China and the EU share a commitment to multilateralism and global governance, which is increasingly important in a world facing complex global challenges. The EU has long been a proponent of multilateralism, actively participating in global initiatives and working through international organizations such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, and the World Health Organization. For the EU, multilateralism is not just a political strategy but also a reflection of its values of inclusivity, collaboration, and peace.

China, too, has embraced multilateralism in its foreign policy, as demonstrated through initiatives such as the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) and the Global Development Initiative (GDI). These initiatives promote global cooperation, trade, and development, with China positioning itself as a key partner in driving international connectivity and economic growth. Additionally, China has actively contributed to global governance by participating in institutions like the G20, the Shanghai Cooperation Organization, and the BRICS bloc, and by taking a leading role in addressing global challenges such as poverty alleviation, global health, and sustainable development.

The United States, particularly under the Trump administration, has increasingly adopted unilateral approaches to global challenges, withdrawing from key international agreements such as the Paris Climate Accord and the World Health Organization. This shift has created a gap in global leadership, with China and the EU stepping in to advocate for multilateral solutions to pressing global issues. By working together, China and the EU can fill this leadership void, advancing global cooperation on issues such as climate change, global trade, and conflict resolution.

Conclusion: A More Multipolar World

The relationship between China, the United States, and Europe is evolving into a more multipolar direction. The EU needs China to help balance the United States. In the context of great power competition, or from the perspective of the China-US-Europe triangle, Trump's victory has made the EU realize that it has to maintain strategic autonomy, increase its influence in international affairs, and establish itself as a key player in a multipolar world. China is increasingly seen as a stable and reliable partner.

At the same time, with Trump back in the White House, the EU may gain more autonomy in shaping its policies toward China, allowing it to prioritize its own interests over those of the United States. In the face of American pressure, China also needs Europe. China must incentivize Europe to act as a balancing pole, while also seeking access to Europe's markets and technology.

In conclusion, a more multipolar relationship between China, the United States, and Europe is beneficial for global stability and development. All three regions should work to advance and strengthen this evolving dynamic.

China and the Global South: Unleashing the Tides of Transformation in the Global Order²²

The Global South has become a powerful force that is reshaping the global order and is setting a course focusing on development and economic globalization that provides opportunities for both China and other leading economies to enhance global economic development together.

The rise of the Global South has become an inescapable and pressing reality that demands our immediate attention, according to Comfort Ero “with a profound and unwavering focus on development and full-scale participation in economic globalization, the Global South is no longer a peripheral force but a central driver of change in the global arena.”²³

Over the past several years, China has been actively forging strategic and meaningful ties with countries of the Global South. Through various cooperation mechanisms, China has contributed to infrastructure building, trade expansion, and technological sharing, playing a significant role in promoting the development of these regions.

However, the development of the Global South is not a task that one country can achieve alone.²⁴ It requires the joint efforts of the international community. China, the United States, and Europe, as major players on the global stage, should put aside differences and collaborate to promote the all-around development of the Global South. Establishing a New Bretton Woods System in a way that incorporates the Global South is not only an absolute necessity but also remarkably advantageous. Additionally, Canada, as an important middle power, has the potential to bridge the relationship between Western countries and the Global South, leveraging its unique position to facilitate dialogue, cooperation, and mutual understanding. Together, we can unleash the full potential of the Global South and reshape the global order in a more inclusive and prosperous way.

The Rise of the Global South

The “Global South” does not have an authoritative international definition. Generally, it refers to developing countries in Africa, Latin America and the Caribbean, Pacific Islands, and Asia.²⁵ After the end of the Cold War, the disintegration of the bipolar system led to a decline in the use of the term “developing countries,” “Third World,”

²² First published in *Southern Powers and Global Dis/Order: Canada Among Nations* 2025, Spring Nature (not published yet) and revised for this collection.

²³ Comfort Ero, “The Trouble With ‘the Global South—What the West Gets Wrong About the Rest”, *Foreign Affairs*, April 1, 2024.

²⁴ Jacqueline Anne Braveboy-Wagner, eds, *Diplomatic Strategies of Rising Nations in the Global South: The Search for Leadership and Influence*, Palgrave Macmillan Cham, 2024.

²⁵ “The Emergence of Global South and its International Influence,” *The Paper*, December 8th, 2023.

and “underdeveloped countries,” while the more moderate and neutral “Global South” has gradually gained popularity as an alternative.²⁶ However, compared with other concepts, the connotation of the “Global South” goes beyond geographical boundaries and economic categories, and more refers to a group of countries with diverse values, cultural traditions, development levels, and diversified interests.

The rise of the Global South reflects profound shifts in the global order. The inception of the current global system is rooted in the Bretton Woods framework of the 1940s. However, since the 1980s, this system which had already departed from the gold standard has faced significant challenges. Developed countries have seen their share of global GDP diminish as the Global South has experienced rapid growth. In recent years, with the expansion of economic globalization and steady progress in South-South cooperation, the overall economic situation in the “Global South” has continued to improve significantly and the grouping has become a major force in promoting world economic growth. Recent data shows that, calculated in terms of purchasing power parity, BRICS countries, largely composed by the “Global South,” now comprise a greater share of global GDP than G7 economies.

The “Global South” has naturally gradually expanded its international influence and pushed for the reform of the global governance system by creating a series of international and regional organizations, including the League of Arab States and the African Union, as well as by participating in major international multilateral conferences such as the BRICS Summit and the G20 Summit. In September 2023, for example, the 18th G20 Summit invited the African Union to become a full member. In the same month, the United Nations General Assembly adopted on a theme of “development” and discussed issues such as climate change and sovereign debt relief, which are major concerns of “Global South” countries. The strategic independence of the “Global South” has also improved, further promoting the democratization of international relations.

Economic Globalization: Key to the Development of the Global South

Many countries in the Global South, having emerged from the grip of colonial rule, are acutely aware of the difficult journey toward economic development.²⁷ Their struggles, marked by sacrifices and relentless efforts, have been focused on forging development paths suited to their unique circumstances. For these nations, economic globalization—which prioritizes economic development—is seen as the key to progress. They tend to prioritize development over ideology or democracy in their approach to international relations and the shared consensus among the Global South is that development remains the highest priority.

²⁶ Joseph S. Nye, “What is the Global South”, China US Focus, November 3, 2023.

²⁷ Oliver Mtapuri, eds, *Poverty, Inequality, and Innovation in the Global South*, Palgrave Macmillan Cham, 2023.

Economic globalization stands in contrast to the rising trends of militarization and populism in many countries. As countries increasingly turn inward, focusing on protectionism and nationalist policies, economic globalization advocates for greater openness, cooperation, and interdependence between nations.²⁸ This clash is evident in the actions of key global players. For example, the United States has adopted more protectionist measures in recent years, imposing tariffs on a range of countries, including China, Canada, and several European nations, under the guise of defending domestic industries and safeguarding the national interest. In contrast, China, recognizing the importance of fostering stronger ties with the developing world, has taken a different approach by reducing or waiving tariffs for the least developed countries (LDCs). This divergence highlights the contrasting approaches to globalization: while some nations move toward economic isolationism, others embrace the idea of fostering international cooperation to drive mutual growth, especially in the Global South countries.

Economic globalization offers numerous advantages to the Global South. In terms of trade, it breaks down barriers, enabling countries in this region to access larger international markets. This allows them to export their unique goods, such as agricultural products, textiles, and handicrafts, which boosts local industries and increases foreign exchange earnings. As a result, livelihoods improve significantly. With more job opportunities in export-oriented sectors, people's incomes rise, leading to better living standards, access to education, and healthcare. Moreover, globalization can drive sustainable development in the Global South. It encourages the transfer of clean technologies and sustainable business practices from developed nations. This helps in promoting resource-efficient production, reducing environmental degradation, and creating a more sustainable economic future.

China Strengthens Strategic Ties with the Global South

Strengthening Unity in the Political Sphere

China, as the world's largest developing nation and an integral part of the "Global South," has a long-standing and profound connection with the Global South. This dates back to 1974, when Deng Xiaoping declared at the sixth special session of the United Nations General Assembly that "China is a developing country and belongs to the Third World," this stance has since stood unwavering. The reiteration in the report of the 20th National Congress of the CPC that China will remain a member of the Global South, regardless of future economic progress and international standing, cementing this identity.

In 2018, President Xi Jinping made reference to the Global South in his closing address at the BRICS Business Forum in Johannesburg, South Africa, and in

²⁸ Jimoh Amzat and Oliver Razum, *Globalization, Health and the Global South: A Critical Approach*, New York: Routledge, 2022.

his subsequent meeting with the press along with South African President Cyril Ramaphosa. There he stressed that “as a developing country and a member of the Global South, China breathes the same breath as other developing countries and pursues a shared future with them.”²⁹ President Xi also made a speech at the first phase of the 19th G20 Summit on November 18, 2024. The announcement of eight actions in support of global development, building on over 1,100 existing development projects, showcases China’s tangible commitment. The establishment of a “Global South” research center and the backing for G20 initiatives that benefit the “Global South” are not just words but deeds that strengthen political bonds.³⁰

The shared historical experiences between China and countries in the Global South form the foundation of their unity. Their struggles, marked by sacrifices and relentless efforts to forge development paths suited to their unique circumstances, closely mirror China’s own journey.³¹ This common heritage has fostered a strong and enduring bond.

During times of global crisis or when the countries of the Global South face external pressures on their sovereignty, security, or development interests, China has consistently stepped up. For example, in international trade disputes where developing countries’ export rights were being curbed unfairly, China used its diplomatic clout and economic leverage to advocate for fairer terms. It has been a vocal defender in multilateral platforms, ensuring that the voices of southern countries are heard and their legitimate rights safeguarded.³²

Emphasizing Economic Development

China and countries of the Global South share similar development challenges and tasks, aiming for development and rejuvenation. Historically, they were at a disadvantage in the international economic interest distribution, with economic backwardness. Even now, the unjust global political and economic system remains largely uncorrected. Developed countries dominate international agenda setting and rulemaking, while issues of unbalanced and insufficient development persist. Global South countries face tougher tasks and greater difficulties in catching up. Moreover, affected by factors like geopolitical conflicts and public health emergencies, the development concerns of the Global South are increasingly marginalized as the international focus shifts to security. Some developed countries tend to politicize economic issues, causing disputes and harming their interests. In response, China advocates for bringing development issues back to the center of the international

²⁹ Li Yan, “Where Did the Term ‘Global South’ Originate?”, China US Focus, September 21, 2023.

³⁰ “Xi Jinping announces eight actions that China will take to support global development,” Xinhua, November 19, 2024.

³¹ Zhao Daojong, “Where exactly is the ‘Global South’?” *Global Times*, June 9, 2023.

³² Yang Hui, “The Rise and Divergence of the Global South and China’s Choice”, *Foreign Affairs Review*, Issue 2, 2024.

agenda and accelerating the implementation of the UN 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, showing its support for the Global South.

China plays a crucial economic role for the Global South.³³ As a major trading partner of over 140 countries with a vast global market, it has acted to reduce tariffs to boost trade. The Belt and Road Initiative reaches 150 countries, mostly developing countries, in the Global South. The Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank and RCEP also contribute to infrastructure building and trade. Despite its economic strength, China still trades as a developing country to assist the Global South. For example, within BRICS, China is a driving force, mediating disputes between countries and promoting technological development in areas like green transitions, communication, and innovation to address climate change. Domestically, China has successfully lifted 800 million people out of poverty, a remarkable achievement and a significant contribution to the world. In this regard, China serves as a model for countries in the Global South.

In its early years, despite its still developing economy, China provided unconditional aid to Third World countries. The Tanzania-Zambia Railway in the 1970s was an iconic project, which provided an interest-free loan of 988 million yuan (about \$400 million) and the shipping of nearly 1 million tons of equipment and materials. Dubbed the “Railway of Freedom” it greatly contributed to Tanzania and Zambia’s socio-economic development and southern Africa’s national liberation movements by bypassing apartheid South Africa and Rhodesia. This support won high praise from Africa and was vital to China garnering support to regain its legitimate seat in the UN during the Cold War when facing international blockades.³⁴

After China’s reform and opening-up, its investment in the Global South mirrored its domestic development model, emphasizing infrastructure. Over the past two decades, China has become Africa’s largest infrastructure investor, participating in more than 200 projects, including 10,000 km of railways, highways, ports, and power transmission lines. The “industrial park” model adopted by Chinese investors has also been successful. By 2021, African nations had 237 industrial parks, with nearly 60 involving Chinese companies, providing new impetus for African industrialization. This not only boosts economic activities but also creates a stable environment essential for further progress. For instance, the Addis Ababa-Djibouti Railway, financed and built with Chinese technology, has slashed transportation costs by nearly 40% for Ethiopian businesses, facilitating trade and regional integration.

China’s economic assistance to Africa is set to continue in the future. The Forum on China-Africa Cooperation Beijing Action Plan (2025–2027) commits 360 billion yuan in financial support in the next three years, covering credit lines, assistance, and direct investment. This package is expected to drive industrial development, infrastructure enhancement, and technological innovation in Africa.

³³ Meng Honghua and Yu Yanfang, “China in the New Era under the Framework of the Global South: Relations with Developing Countries”, *International Review*, Issue 1, 2024.

³⁴ Huiyao Wang, “The evolving landscape of China-Africa cooperation”, CGTN, September 9, 2024.

China's cooperation with the Global South benefits recipients without imposing additional conditions. Unlike investment by other countries in Africa, China takes on mundane but critical work like road construction and mining. As leaders from Namibia and Honduras point out, China respects the principles of self-determination and non-interference, building relations based on mutual respect and mutual benefit. Having benefited from China's rapid development in the past, developed countries are intentionally or not now trying to prevent the Global South from enjoying the same benefits.

Increasing Technological Exchange

The relationship between China and the Global South has evolved remarkably. What began as a predominant focus on building basic infrastructure has metamorphosed into a more holistic endeavor. Nowadays, it's not just about bricks and mortar but about fueling sustainable and high-quality growth, with technology exchange and green initiatives taking center stage. In recent years, China has been a key player in Africa's green transformation. Since 2021, 120-plus climate-related projects have appeared across the continent. For instance, in Kenya, China has been involved in solar power plant projects, installing advanced photovoltaic panels that can generate clean electricity for thousands of households, reducing reliance on fossil fuels.

To ensure the seamless progression of these development and technology exchange programs, China has made tangible commitments to regional security. China has dispatched peacekeeping forces or observers to multiple African countries, including Sudan, where they've helped maintain order and normalcy. This is far from a symbolic gesture as a stable environment is crucial for development technology transfer to take root. In Mali, for example, Chinese peacekeepers have safeguarded key infrastructure, allowing for the uninterrupted installation of telecommunication networks, which are vital for the digital technology that locals can use to access online educational resources and engage in the digital economy.

Using China's technological know-how to access Africa's bountiful sustainable energy reserves has resulted in fruitful collaborations. The 19 South-South cooperation memorandums on climate change with 17 African countries have paved the way for a surge in joint projects. In Ethiopia, Chinese firms have teamed up with local partners to build wind farms equipped with state-of-the-art turbines, whose real-time monitoring and control systems are based on Chinese digital technology. This synergy is a prime example of how technology exchange can drive environmental progress, as Africans gain hands-on experience with advanced engineering and digital management tools from China.³⁵

³⁵ Huiyao Wang, "How China and the West can join hands to truly help Africa", *South China Morning Post*, September 23, 2024.

China, the United States, Europe, and the Global Community: Unifying Efforts to Promote the Development of the Global South

As the Global South emerges as a significant player in the world, the international community should collaborate to support and advance its development. China, the United States, and Europe should work together to promote the development of the Global South.³⁶ China has already been spearheading efforts in international cooperation with the Global South, both through bilateral engagements as well as international organizations to foster Africa's sustainable development.

The United States will not be able to ignore the Global South's collective demands,³⁷ particularly after Trump is re-elected. "The markets and materials that these countries possess will only become more central to solving problems that the incoming president expresses great interest in addressing, such as bolstering US supply chains and securing critical minerals."³⁸ The United States, in a strategic pivot, has introduced initiatives like the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor. This ambitious project, slated to allocate billions in investment, aims to reassert its influence in the Global South. Preliminary estimates suggest it could boost trade volumes between participating regions by up to 25% in the next five years if fully implemented.

Japan, too, is making strides. At recent G20 meetings, it pledged an additional \$5 billion in development aid for climate resilience projects in the Global South, doubling its previous commitment. Europe, with its Green Deal for the Global South, plans to allocate €300 billion over the next decade to support sustainable transitions, seeking to mend frayed relations.

India, straddling the North-South divide, is leveraging its position. It hosts annual conclaves like the Raisina Dialogue, inviting leaders from both hemispheres to discuss global challenges. India convened a virtual summit of developing countries in 2023, perhaps a tad presumptuously called the Voice of the Global South, which ambitiously claimed "unity of thought, unity of purpose."³⁹ In Africa, Indian IT companies have set up over 50 training centers, equipping local youth with digital skills, aiming to create a talent pool for future tech collaborations. Russia, meanwhile, has focused on energy and food security partnerships. In the past year alone, it has signed long-term grain supply contracts with 10 African nations, ensuring food stability. While its energy deals, such as building refineries in Algeria, have

³⁶ "Who's the big boss of the Global South?" *The Economist*, April 8, 2024.

³⁷ Yang Sen, "The US and the West want to lead the 'Global South' to where?" *Beijing Daily*, September 22, 2023.

³⁸ Leslie Vinjamuri and Max Yoeli, "America's Last Chance With the Global South", *Foreign Affairs*, November 15, 2024.

³⁹ Alan Beattie, "The 'Global South' is a pernicious term that needs to be retired", *Financial Times*, September 14, 2023.

strengthened economic ties, with exports to the region growing by 15% annually.⁴⁰ Meanwhile, Russia hosted both a Russia-Africa summit and a first international parliamentary conference of Latin American countries as well as the Islamic World Kazan forum, with more than 11,000 delegates from 79 countries.⁴¹

China's third-party cooperation models are also yielding remarkable results. The partnership with France in Cameroon's Kribi Deep Seaport is a case in point. Since its inception, the port's throughput has tripled, handling over 10 million tons of cargo last year, benefiting not just Cameroon but also its landlocked neighbors. Furthermore, despite competitive undertones, cooperation with Japan is also budding. After the 2018 forum, multiple joint ventures in solar energy projects have emerged. In Kenya, a Chinese-Japanese consortium built a 50-megawatt solar farm, combining Japanese technologies with Chinese cost-effective manufacturing, reducing electricity costs for local industries by 20%.

Multilateral institutions are the linchpins of global cooperation efforts. The AIIB, with its growing membership of over 100 countries, has co-financed projects worth \$20 billion in Africa. The collaboration with the African Development Bank on water infrastructure projects, like the expansion of water treatment plants in Nigeria, has provided clean water to millions. The issuance of Egypt's "panda bond" under the AIIB's guidance, amounting to \$500 million, showcases how financial innovation can mobilize resources for sustainable development, setting a precedent for other emerging economies.

Cooperating with the Global South should not be siloed or rather, it should be a strategic approach that integrates smoothly with the broader international community and strengthens global cohesion. This cooperation should be grounded in the principles of mutual benefit, equality, and win-win outcomes, not seeking to create parallel or exclusive systems,⁴² but rather aiming to bridge gaps and complement existing international cooperation frameworks. By sharing development experiences, technologies, and resources, it fosters stronger ties among nations. It promotes a sense of unity where both Western countries and the Global South work toward shared goals such as poverty reduction, sustainable energy adoption, and climate change mitigation. This model of cooperation does not disrupt the international order but enriches it, making the global community more inclusive and cohesive, with each part contributing its unique strengths for the collective good.⁴³

⁴⁰ Huiyao Wang, "How China can step up to its responsibilities in a rising Global South", *South China Morning Post*, August 22, 2023.

⁴¹ Natalie Sabanadze, "Russia is using the Soviet playbook in the Global South to challenge the West—and it is working", Chatham House, May 16, 2024.

⁴² Murphy Dawn, "China's rise in the Global South: the Middle East, Africa, and Beijing's alternative world order", *The China Quarterly*, vol. 252, Stanford University Press, 2022.

⁴³ Gustavo de Carvalho, "Global South: The 'Rest' vs the West?" Italian Institute for International Political Studies, December 21, 2023.

Establishing a New Bretton Woods System to Incorporate the Global South

Establishing a New Bretton Woods System involves reimagining global governance to better address the pressing challenges of climate change, economic inequality, and geopolitical power imbalances. A key aspect of this system is increasing the voice and influence of the Global South, ensuring their active participation in shaping global policy decisions that directly affect their development, climate resilience, and economic future. This includes promoting multilateralism as a foundational principle, where countries collaborate on shared global goals, particularly in tackling climate change and achieving sustainable development. Additionally, the creation of a G10 focused on the world's top ten carbon-emitting nations can drive urgent and equitable emissions reduction efforts. This platform would hold the most significant emitters accountable while recognizing the historical and current disparities in responsibility. Furthermore, an AI summit with substantial Global South participation is crucial to addressing the transformative role of artificial intelligence in the global economy. By including voices from countries that have historically been excluded from these discussions, the summit would help ensure that AI technologies are developed and deployed in ways that benefit all nations equitably, particularly those in the Global South, by tackling issues such as digital inequality and access to technology.

Canada, as a Middle Power, Can Play an Important Role

Canada has long been recognized as an important middle power on the global stage, alongside countries like Australia, Japan, and Türkiye. As a middle power, Canada occupies a unique position in international relations, balancing its strong economic and political ties with both major powers and emerging nations. The country enjoys vast natural resources, a highly educated population, and an innovative workforce, which position it as a key player in global affairs. Moreover, Canada's significant soft power—shaped by its values of multiculturalism, peacekeeping, and diplomatic engagement—further strengthens its influence on the world stage. This combination of attributes enables Canada to play a critical mediating role between major powers and to bridge gaps between the Global South and the West. Given its reputation for fairness, pragmatism, and diplomatic finesse, Canada can help facilitate dialogue and collaboration in complex international issues, fostering cooperation across diverse regions and interests.

Having pursued my PhD at the University of Western Ontario, I have gained a deep and comprehensive appreciation of Canada's role in world affairs. This exposure has enhanced my appreciation for how Canada's middle power status allows it to navigate international conflicts and forge constructive relationships, particularly with the Global South. With its strong commitment to multilateralism and human rights,

Canada remains a trusted voice in global discussions, offering a unique perspective on bridging divides between the Global South and the rest of the world.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the rise of the Global South is not just a passing trend but an established and powerful force that is reshaping the global order. With development and economic globalization at its core, the Global South is charting a new course for itself and the world at large.

The events at the 22nd Doha Forum on December 7, 2024, especially the joint session by the Center for China and Globalization (CCG) and the Doha Forum, “China’s Role in the Rising Global South: Redefining the Future World Order,” have been a remarkable success. The in-depth discussions among eminent leaders and experts explored various aspects of China’s influence on the Global South, from economic and political impacts to the transformation of the global trade network and international institutions. These exchanges are not only crucial for future China-Global South relations but also serve as a model for international cooperation in promoting the development of the Global South.

I am confident that with continued efforts like those demonstrated at the Doha Forum, and with the joint endeavors of all countries concerned, the Global South will continue to thrive. It will not only achieve its own development goals but also contribute to a more balanced, just, and prosperous global order. The future of the Global South is full of promise, and the world should actively support and participate in this remarkable journey of transformation.

Alliances Like NATO Are Out of Touch with a World in Need of Human Security⁴⁴

Security for individual nations and humanity as a whole is not mutually exclusive or in conflict and, organizations should focus on ensuring the security of humanity above myopic national security considerations.

In an era of increasing global interdependence, the traditional focus on ensuring security through military-focused alliances is no longer sufficient to address today's global challenges.

While recent NATO summits have reaffirmed the strength of such alliances, they have also highlighted their limitations in tackling twenty-first-century threats. There is an urgent need to shift toward prioritizing human security, a concept that encompasses climate change, food security, energy, and poverty alleviation.

NATO's potential expansion into the Indo-Pacific region through countries such as Australia, Japan, South Korea, and New Zealand raises questions about the role of such alliances in today's interconnected world. This move reflects a security approach that might not be fit for purpose given current global dynamics.

While the transatlantic alliance has embraced more political and economic approaches alongside military considerations, the effectiveness of these strategies in promoting peace and development is debatable. These approaches run the risk of unintentionally fueling regional tensions and call for a re-evaluation of traditional security alliances' long-term impact on global human security.

The emphasis on national security often overshadows pressing global issues such as economic globalization and effective climate governance. Global cooperation in these areas will benefit both developed and developing nations. In this context, efforts such as the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership and the Belt and Road Initiative aim to address these global challenges while offering potential mutual benefits.

A key consideration in the current global context is balancing national and human security. Promoting human security can serve national interests as well. This balance involves advancing domestic development, addressing other nations' concerns and participating in international cooperation.

The 2020s have witnessed the rise of human security threats in climate, food, energy, and poverty. These interconnected crises demand collective action as no country can effectively address them on its own.

The COVID-19 pandemic and regional conflicts have disrupted global supply chains, further complicating the global landscape and contributing to energy crises. Energy has become increasingly politicized, leading to misalignments between resources and consumption, as well as capital and demand.

Sanctions on Russian energy exports during its invasion of Ukraine have affected both Russia and Western Europe, resulting in elevated energy prices. As a result, some

⁴⁴ First published on August 2, 2024 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

countries have delayed their low-carbon commitments and returned to investing in fossil fuels, potentially exacerbating climate issues.

The effects of climate change continue to intensify. Last year was reportedly the warmest on record, with rising sea levels and melting glaciers posing threats globally.

A report released in January by the World Economic Forum and Oliver Wyman projects dire health consequences from climate change by 2050, including as many as 14.5 million additional deaths and US\$12.5 trillion in economic losses. It also estimates an addition US\$1.1 trillion in extra costs to global healthcare systems. These stark figures underline the urgency of addressing climate change as a critical component of human security.

Meanwhile, Russia's invasion of Ukraine has contributed to a global food crisis. Both sides are major grain producers who have reduced exports amid the conflict. Combined with the pandemic and climate crisis, the war in Ukraine has sustained high food prices and exacerbated global hunger.

The United Nations' 2023 State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World report shows that between 691 and 783 million people faced hunger worldwide in 2022, an increase of 122 million hungry people since 2019. In addition, 2.4 billion people worldwide—almost 30 percent of the world's population—lacked consistent access to food, with about 900 million facing severe food insecurity.

The compound crises of climate and food security have raised living costs and driven up homelessness, making poverty alleviation an even more critical focus. According to UN figures released last year, 1.1 billion people remain in poverty, with children in poverty accounting for half that figure.

This increase in global poverty not only undermines individual well-being but also poses risks to social stability and security. However, the United Nations offers reasons for optimism and notes that poverty reduction is achievable provided there is robust global cooperation and increased assistance from developed countries.

Infrastructure security is another critical global challenge. Significant deficits, especially in developing regions, threaten economic growth and human security. Collaboration between the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank and institutions such as the World Bank could significantly enhance efforts to bridge global infrastructure gaps, contributing to sustainable development and global resilience.

In conclusion, global development trends must prioritize human security alongside traditional national security concerns. The upcoming UN Summit of the Future in September offers a crucial platform for reaffirming multilateralism and UN Charter principles. Unlike traditional security alliances, this form of international dialogue and cooperation is better equipped to address the complex issues facing the world today and provide an opportunity for countries to collaborate on new challenges while rebuilding trust in global institutions.

We must address pressing global challenges and prepare for a more resilient future. This includes developing effective multilateral solutions to accelerate the delivery of the UN's Sustainable Development Goals, tackle climate change with concrete action and navigate the complexities of emerging technologies such as artificial intelligence.

Priority should be given to global food security and poverty reduction as fundamental aspects of human security. Only by shifting our focus from narrow national interests to this more comprehensive view of human security can we create a world that is safer, sustainable, and more equitable.

As US-China Rivalry Heats Up, Soft Power Competition Need Not Be a Zero-Sum Game⁴⁵

The United States and China should work to restore cultural exchange, academic ties, governmental dialogue, and boost travel, while also increase collaboration on shared challenges.

In the past three decades, few concepts have been more influential in international relations than the idea of soft power. The term was coined in 1990 by political scientist Joseph Nye to describe the ability to get what you want through attraction, rather than coercion or payment.

Today, it feels like we are living in an age of intense soft power competition as the struggle between great powers extends beyond military and economic affairs into the realm of stories, images, and information.

After the United States lost soft power during the Trump years, President Joe Biden made a concerted push to restore the country's moral stature. He has made values central to foreign policy, positioning the United States as the chief defender of the liberal order and pitting democracies against autocracies.

China has also embraced the idea of soft power. Leaders have stressed its importance and made large investments in public diplomacy. The concept has been the topic of countless papers and books published by Chinese scholars, as well as several seminars at our think tank, the Center for China and Globalization.

As great power rivalry heats up, soft power is often seen as a zero-sum game, a battle for influence and narratives between Washington and Beijing in which one side's loss is the other's gain. But as Nye stressed in our recent dialogue to mark the release of his new book, while the competitive aspects of soft power are undeniable, we should also remember that there are ways it can bring joint gains. This is an important insight as rising tensions between China and the United States fuel talk of another Cold War.

As Nye noted in our talk, our geopolitical situation is quite different from the US-Soviet face-off. Firstly, economic globalization and value chains have bound the great powers of our age in a way quite unlike during the Cold War. For all the talk of decoupling, China-US trade in goods hit a record US\$690.6 billion last year.

Second, even if a degree of economic decoupling does occur in some fields, China and the United States are forever bound by an "ecological interdependence." Climate change and pandemics threaten both sides because carbon emissions and viruses do not respect borders.

Nye calls China-US relations a "cooperative rivalry" because these global challenges demand cooperation even as the two sides compete. Unfortunately, amid the clamor over Taiwan, spy balloons, and tech sanctions, there is too much emphasis on "rivalry" and not nearly enough on "cooperation."

In 2009, Nye and Chinese scholar Wang Jisi described how soft power enables China-US cooperation, because it is much easier to work together if both sides like

⁴⁵ First published on May 12, 2023 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

each other. If China is seen as unattractive in the United States and demonized in the media or politics, the American public and policymakers are less likely to support cooperation with Beijing—and vice versa. Unfortunately, negative views of the “other side” now dominate in both countries, hindering cooperation on shared interests.

It doesn't have to be this way. During the Cold War, even as Washington and Moscow threatened to destroy each other, American and Soviet scientists worked together to develop a vaccine for polio. In 2003, the United States and China joined forces to combat the Severe Acute Respiratory Syndrome (SARS) outbreak. Unfortunately, such cooperation was lacking when it came to COVID-19, which probably worsened the impact of the pandemic.

China and the United States are the world's two biggest economies and carbon emitters. They are also the two science superpowers, accounting for over a third of the world's research personnel and two-fifths of the scholarly output. If the two sides cannot work together, it will seriously undermine humanity's ability to deal with the next pandemic, not to mention other global challenges like climate change.

One way the United States and China can start to rebuild soft power is to restore their cultural ties and cooperation in research and academia, which have dwindled in recent years due to politics and the pandemic.

On top of delivering economic benefits and scientific progress, restoring bilateral academic exchange would help China and the United States to improve mutual respect and understanding. Interactions with local colleagues are a catalyst for deeper interpersonal and commercial ties, trust, and a sense of connection that can withstand bilateral frictions.

Academic exchange is crucial for the next generation of Chinese and American policymakers, entrepreneurs, and scientists to be able to understand and work with each other. A 2022 survey shows that Chinese people who have studied or traveled in the United States have more positive attitudes toward the country.

It is also important that more American students cross the Pacific to study, learn Chinese and build a pipeline of China literacy. But while there are about 295,000 Chinese studying in US universities, there are only around 350 American students on Chinese campuses, down from thousands a decade ago.

Now that China's borders are open, both sides should work to restore academic exchanges and other cultural ties such as in tourism, as well as bilateral meetings at various levels of government. Both sides could explore questions such as: Do Chinese laws oblige Chinese companies to turn over foreign data at the government's request, and does China's military-civil fusion policy mandate that private Chinese companies have to turn over technology to the People's Liberation Army, as many insist in the United States? We think not.

Overzealous competition and disengagement will only hurt both countries' soft power in the rest of the world. But if China and the United States can work together to solve challenges like climate change or finding an end to the war in Ukraine, they can boost their influence and help inspire global cooperation.

A Close-Up Look at New Trends in China-US-EU Relations⁴⁶

Despite the ultimate retreat of the pandemic, the damage done in terms of the world's understanding of China was severe and exchanges must be pushed to improve both diplomatic and economic relations.

In the decade before the COVID-19 pandemic ravaged the world, delegations from the Center for China and Globalization had visited counterparts across the Pacific in the United States at least twice a year. However, the unabated spread of the virus has to a large extent hindered exchanges between the two countries.

This year's unusual journey marks the first time in more than two years that CCG has made an international visit. This one-month Track II diplomatic tour, a tour of non-governmental and people-to-people diplomacy, started in Singapore, followed by New York and Washington, DC, in the United States, then Paris, Berlin, and Brussels in Europe, and finally Seoul in the Republic of Korea, with the goal of communicating face to face with leaders and experts from local think tanks, academia, and business circles.

To our knowledge, this is the first Chinese think tank delegation to visit the United States since COVID-19 broke out, which is a positive signal that people-to-people exchanges are returning.

The Ecosystem

Human and cultural exchanges between China and the United States have been stagnant or at times even nonexistent for more than two years. Grievances and misunderstandings have increased despite virtual talks, and even after extensive and intense dialogue, we can still feel unprecedented negative sentiment toward China in the United States.

However, at the same time, we were moved by the warm welcome we received. And the enthusiasm of people wanting to visit China as well as the desire for return to some level of stability in Sino-US relations and the resumption of bilateral cultural and people-to-people exchanges were still there.

Probably because we hadn't seen each other for quite some time, everyone had a lot to say and there were seemingly endless questions. Many of the events we participated in ran over time. Many US colleagues are quite dissatisfied with the current lack of communication between the two sides and some scholars at the conferences and meetings cited negative sentiment on the US side and long quarantines required in China as probably being the major barrier keeping them from coming to China—challenges that forced many of them to change or cancel plans to come here. Many young Americans who were planning to study Chinese language and culture on the Chinese mainland had to either cancel their trip to China or go to other places instead.

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Since the outbreak of the pandemic, the number of American students studying in China has plunged, affecting an entire generation of “China hands,” people with expert knowledge of the language, culture and people of China, in the United States. Also, it is more and more difficult for Americans to carry out exchanges with China due to the current climate of anti-China sentiment in the United States.

The Sino-US relationship is an ecosystem that requires the constant cultivation of new minds, but there was a clear lack of these young minds in Washington. The older generation of China hands like Kenneth G. Lieberthal and Douglas H. Paal have retired and left Washington, while the attitude of younger generations toward China has become less nuanced as they lack a broad and in-depth knowledge base, having been unable to visit China since the pandemic began, and lack first-hand information about China today. This will be detrimental to Sino-US relations in the long run.

Feedback from business circles was essentially the same as that of academia. US enterprises are very concerned about the impact of geopolitics, particularly the Russia-Ukraine war. They are worried about the worsening of US-China relations and a potential crisis in the Taiwan Strait.

Still, many American businesses remain pragmatic and positive, maintaining healthy Sino-US economic relations. Interest in China remains high and many businesses hope to return to China as soon as possible. Nonetheless, they worry that if they develop a close relationship with China, they will feel pressure on multiple fronts. They also find it difficult to address negative perceptions of China as there is a more acute lack of understanding about the country right now. However, it isn’t only business people that are feeling this pressure; even the more rational views of China experts in the United States are not being heard, which is frustrating for them.

The pandemic and rising geopolitical conflicts in recent years, for example, the Ukraine crisis, have complicated relations between the world’s two largest economies. The lack of face-to-face communication and private exchanges between the two sides has led to strategic misjudgment and disinformation by some US policymakers on China.

Additionally, as the United States struggles to cope with economic problems, such as inflation and supply chain disruptions, and a series of COVID-19 impacts, China, unfortunately, has been widely used as a scapegoat to sway US public opinion. The US Government has now put almost 1,100 Chinese companies on sanctions lists, which has severely damaged Sino-US trade relations.

A large number of scholars who study China, many of whom have profound expertise on China research and hold an objective stance on Sino-US relations, have failed to keep their research on China up to date during the pandemic. Most information coming from Western media and the small number of Chinese English-language media is far from sufficient. There are few English language research reports published by Chinese think tanks. As a result, it is difficult for these Western scholars to maintain their accuracy and influence as they plan policy recommendations, which in turn upsets the status quo.

Many in the United States feel a sense of urgency in enhancing bilateral exchanges, hoping to promote visits, overseas study, and tourism. Some suggest that China and the United States should work to restore people-to-people and cultural exchanges

as soon as possible to improve public sentiment, and then consider what to do next. Some proposed solutions in this regard include US personnel visiting China, adopting a “closed-loop” model similar to that used during the 2022 Beijing Olympic and Paralympic Games, enabling both sides to sit down and have a face-to-face conversation.

Issue-Based Solutions

Representatives from both sides raised concerns about many issues in Sino-US relations during our meetings. For example, businesses we met with in New York expressed concern about Chinese enterprises listing on US stock exchanges being delisted and the tightening of regulations. They also raised many questions about China’s economic development, its COVID-19 prevention policy, and its stance on the Russia-Ukraine war. We answered them frankly and based on the actual situation in China.

State-owned enterprise subsidies and fair competition issues are what concern the United States most now. At present, the number of Chinese companies on the Fortune 500 list exceeds that of American companies. Many American multinational companies believe that entering the Chinese market means competing with state-owned enterprises, which are thought to be under constant state sponsorship.

To address the above issues, we explained to them that Chinese central and local governments are giving more support to the implementation of opening-up policies, ensuring a fair business environment as well as introducing preferential policies for enterprise development. The Ministry of Commerce has set up the National Center for Complaints of Foreign-Invested Enterprises to provide timely feedback and help multinationals understand relevant policies.

The Foreign Investment Law took effect in 2020. The law aims to make foreign investment policies more transparent and ensure domestic and foreign companies are subject to a unified set of rules and compete on a level playing field. New free trade zones have recently been established, and other opening-up policies are being implemented. More measures have entered the pipeline since the Central Government began its application to join the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership, an 11-member trade pact, and the Digital Economy Partnership Agreement, an international agreement that seeks to bolster digital trade. This means that there is much work ahead to increase China’s openness.

As one of the largest markets in the world, as well as a country with abundant manufacturing capacity, China is always an ideal destination for foreign investment. The country welcomes foreign entrepreneurs to do business. This is a doctrine that has never been changed and will remain the same, despite the turbulence of global geopolitics. China will one day become the largest market in the world that no multinational corporations can afford to abandon.

We also stressed that multinational enterprises, for their part, should first understand and respect China’s sovereignty and observe Chinese regulations. They can

establish a better image by assuming corporate social responsibility and participating in telling the true story of China.

Despite different understandings on both sides, discussions were frank and straightforward, but overall, those we met in the United States tended to talk about specific issues. Therefore, while it is necessary to emphasize a “mutually beneficial” macro strategy, it is necessary that we put more emphasis on taking initial steps in solving issues, such as people-to-people and cultural and media exchanges to stabilize bilateral relations, starting small and solving fundamental problems that are impeding efforts to improve Sino-US relations.

Some US officials echoed the need to restart Sino-US relations by finding concrete solutions to specific issues, while think tank leaders proposed reducing “Microphone Diplomacy” between the United States and China—namely the practice common to both countries of holding debates via public speeches—to take the rhetoric down a notch, talk less about major issues, and focus on solving specific issues.

China-US-EU Balance

The overall atmosphere in Europe was quite different from before the pandemic. Europe has learned to live with the virus and tourism and service industries have fully recovered with subways and other public spaces busy and crowded. Though there was a general dissatisfaction with the inconvenience of reduced flights to and from China. Many hoped that normal flights would resume quickly and that people-to-people and cultural exchanges such as tourism and study could continue.

The Russia-Ukraine war has had a significant impact on China-EU relations with Europeans generally harboring an increasingly negative view of China as they feel it has sided with Russia in the war. The EU’s largest economies, France and Germany, are preparing to publish strategic policy reports aimed at China and during our visit, we found ourselves constantly reassured them of China’s emphasis on respecting the sovereignty and territorial integrity of other countries as well as China’s desire to promote peace talks. We believe that a great deal more work needs to be done to build trust and dispel doubts.

The China-EU Comprehensive Agreement on Investment (CAI) has been on hold for more than a year, and a new round of review will begin in October this year. But what will come of it? Can the China-EU five-year economic cooperation plan be rekindled? Will China and the EU hold high-level meetings in the near future? Can the proposed investment plans be implemented? Can sanctions on both sides be lifted so that the CAI can be actualized? These are some of the questions we discussed during our visit.

Face-to-face communication is far more effective than online meetings. Sitting together makes it easier for people to open up, share more information, and resolve misunderstandings. People-to-people exchanges between China and the EU can act as a catalyst to warm relations. Europeans have taken our visit as a signal that China is gradually opening up channels for offline communication, and we are also working

hard to promote cooperation and exchange. It is this kind of communication that will decide whether the CAI and many other issues begin to resume progress.

In the wake of the Russia-Ukraine war, the relationship between Europe and the United States has become stronger, and the two sides have become closer in terms of ideology and values.

However, China is the EU's largest trading partner and while the bloc's political security may be more closely dependent on the United States, economic security and trade are more dependent on China. China and Europe have many things in common and we should work to cooperate more on issues like climate change and the digital economy.

A mechanism for high-level dialogue and coordination between China, the United States, and the EU would play a positive role in promoting world peace and common development. We proposed the concept of a "G3" during our time in Europe, which places Europe in a key position as a balancing role between China and the United States and would contribute greatly to maintaining stability in geopolitics and international relations.

Biden's Indo-Pacific Framework Cannot Succeed without China⁴⁷

The back and forth instability of US policy on Asia from Obama to Trump to Biden and back again has weakened US credibility with Asian countries. If the United States wants to both decarbonize Asia and convince countries to buy into IPEF then, it should look to China for cooperation.

On May 23, President Joe Biden unveiled his Indo-Pacific Economic Framework, a long-sought out plan to boost US economic engagement in the region. While details are yet to be fleshed out, the plan will be a tough sell, as reflected by reports that it was watered down at the last minute to attract more countries.

The first problem is credibility. Over the last decade, America's role in Asia has been a swirl of short-lived acronyms and aspirations that come and go with the political winds in Washington.

After the United States withdrew from Barack Obama's own Trans-Pacific Partnership and the subsequent demise of Donald Trump's free and open Indo-Pacific, Asian leaders will be forgiven for looking askance at the IPEF, especially with Biden's own political fortunes flagging and the looming possibility of a second Trump presidency.

The second, larger problem is that IPEF just does not offer much to developing economies. Domestic politics mean that Biden cannot offer the kind of market-access incentives that were crucial in persuading countries like Vietnam to accept stricter standards when the original TPP was negotiated. What is left is an American wish list of commitments and little in the way of tangible benefits.

Most countries in Asia welcome deeper US economic engagement in the region. But they do not want to be reduced to pawns on a chessboard and be forced to choose between the United States and China, which for most is a far more important economic partner.

As Singaporean academic Kishore Mahbubani points out, Southeast Asian nations are less interested in talk of "freedom" and "openness" and more interested in the material needs of the region and its recovery from the pandemic.

If Biden wants to secure buy-in for IPEF and prove it is more than a geopolitical tool to further US interests, he will have to show it can deliver practical benefits outside the traditional market-access channel. Looking down the list of items that President Biden outlined in Tokyo, infrastructure and climate change is the pillar that stands out.

The Asia-Pacific is a make-or-break battlefield in our fight against climate change. It is home to the world's most populous and fastest-growing economies, accounts for over half of global carbon emissions, and is highly exposed to extreme weather events, as shown by the recent heat waves in South Asia.

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However, the region also faces significant developmental challenges, including an annual infrastructure spending gap of \$1.7 trillion, and is decarbonizing much more slowly than the global average.

Washington needs to do more than arm-twist countries into more ambitious climate targets if it wants to play a meaningful role in decarbonizing Asia. It should also make a sustained commitment to support investment in green infrastructure, which would accelerate both the transition to clean energy and equitable recovery from the pandemic.

This brings us to the elephant in the room. Can IPEF make a real difference in scaling up climate-friendly investments if it excludes Asia's largest economy, the hub of its supply chains, not to mention the world leader in affordable infrastructure and renewable energy solutions?

Formal cooperation with China on green infrastructure under IPEF, or for that matter, the Belt and Road Initiative, may be a tall order in the current political atmosphere. After all, Biden's new framework is crafted for strategic competition with China, which Biden, like his predecessor, sees as the central theme of the bilateral relationship.

However, unlike Trump, Biden takes climate change seriously and is willing to work with China to address it.

As vice president, he played a key role in a program of climate cooperation with China that was instrumental in the 2015 Paris agreement and saw fruitful collaborations between companies from both countries under the US-China Climate Change Working Group. The group was abandoned by Trump but is now set to be revived following a rare bilateral breakthrough at the 26th UN Climate Change Conference of the Parties, or COP26, last November.

If they can put aside their differences and work together, the United States and China have the clout and complementary capabilities to drive real progress in decarbonizing Asia. China is a top manufacturer of climate-friendly technologies such as wind and solar; the United States is a leader in systems that integrate these products into power grids and cities.

There are many synergies to be gained by combining China's strengths in hard infrastructure with America's expertise in soft infrastructure, such as standards, governance, and institutions.

One step forward would be to form a new action initiative under the revived climate working group to facilitate bilateral cooperation in third countries in Asia. This would allow information sharing, dialogue, and some degree of coordination between the United States and China in promoting green infrastructure across the region.

It could also be a vehicle to match and enable collaboration between US and Chinese companies in working with host countries to unlock green opportunities in fields such as clean energy, green buildings, and smart cities.

Critics of IPEF say it is merely a tool to contain China that offers little benefit to the region. Biden can prove they are wrong by equipping the framework to make a sustained and meaningful contribution to decarbonizing Asia. This mammoth task,

on which all our futures depend, can only be achieved if all the key actors work together.

Biden knows that great powers must learn to coexist and face challenges that cannot be overcome alone. He has promised his China strategy will strike a balance between competition and cooperation.

Finding ways to work with Beijing to amplify the green benefits of the IPEF and the BRI would be a great place to start.

How a “G3” Mechanism Could Reset US-China-EU Relations and Tackle Global Challenges⁴⁸

In a post-pandemic world, the United States, China, and the EU must work together to deal with global issues and a G3 mechanism that brings them together rather than cleaving the world into competing spheres would make that easier.

During the past two years, in-person academic exchange between China and Europe has ground to a halt because of the COVID-19 pandemic and restrictions on travel in and out of China.

To start in reviving these interactions, a delegation from the Center for China and Globalization visited Paris, Berlin, and Brussels in early August 2022, attending seminars and meeting with representatives from think tanks and government agencies.

It was the first trip to Europe by a Chinese think tank delegation since the pandemic began and part of a global engagement tour that also took us to New York, Washington, Seoul, and Singapore. My last visit to Europe was for the Munich Security Conference in February 2020, which turned out to be one of the last major gatherings of global policymakers before cross-border travel ceased because of the pandemic.

Since then, Europe’s political landscape and views of China have shifted significantly. Angela Merkel, who served for 16 years as German chancellor, was Europe’s leading proponent of stronger ties with China, has left the scene. Her replacement Olaf Scholz and the coalition government he leads seem determined to pursue a harder line on China.

The issue of human rights in Xinjiang has also become more contentious and led the European Union and China to impose sanctions on each other. These sanctions are up for renewal this year and we hope both sides can find a way to drop them.

The war in Ukraine was a dominant topic in our discussions. Across Europe, it has caused countries to rethink foreign policy and further soured perceptions of China, given the widely held view that Beijing has not done enough to oppose Russian President Vladimir Putin’s invasion.

While we were in Europe, the French and German governments appeared to be moving toward taking a stronger stance on China. Across the channel, the unfolding contest to become Britain’s next prime minister has seen the two remaining candidates trying to outdo each other in being toughest on China.

Despite these hardening views, the think tanks, foundations, and EU officials we met were keen to rekindle engagement with China and expressed a desire for closer cooperation on shared interests.

After all, China remains the EU’s largest trading partner and is seen as an important player on global challenges such as climate change and reforming multilateralism.

Although Europe is preoccupied with the war in Ukraine, the question of how to recalibrate ties with Beijing and navigate the increasingly complex China-US relationship remains a crucial question for EU policymakers. French President Emmanuel

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Macron, who has emerged as one of the EU’s leading voices in the post-Merkel era, has spoken of the need for the EU to be a “balancing power.”

Russia’s invasion of Ukraine and the subsequent reinvigoration of NATO is a serious challenge to hopes for EU “strategic autonomy”. Yet, in this age of polycrisis, the need for the EU to come into its own as an influential geopolitical player and to promote international peace and cooperation has never been greater.

China, the EU and the United States are the world’s three most powerful political and economic players, together accounting for around 60% of global gross domestic product. At present, global cooperation is hamstrung by tensions between China and the United States, but the EU could be the one power able to play a mediating role between the two.

If these three parties can come to the table, they have the clout to address current economic challenges and galvanize collective action on threats such as climate change and the pandemic, and spur reform of global governance. That is why, in recent meetings with European counterparts, we emphasized the concept of a “G3” mechanism that brings together China, the EU and the United States for regular high-level dialogue and coordination.

To get the ball rolling, this “G3” could start with urgent but less contentious issues. Tackling the current global food security crisis is a promising area to find common ground. These efforts could build on the agreement reached by China and the EU to maintain stability in the global supply chain, including by discussing how to increase transparency and exchange information on the supply of certain critical raw materials and other products.

Amid this summer’s heatwaves, climate change stands out as a clear area for long-term G3 cooperation. China, the EU and the United States account for around 40% of global greenhouse gas emissions and consume nearly half the world’s energy.

Together, they have the critical mass to drive the global climate agenda forward and influence economic pathways—and therefore emissions trajectories—far beyond their borders. One area to work on would be developing a common framework for green finance and supporting decarbonization projects in other countries.

On that note, the G3 could also serve as a forum to achieve some degree of coordination on global infrastructure development between the Belt and Road Initiative, the EU’s Global Gateway, and the new Group of Seven Partnership on Global Infrastructure and Investment. If investments under these initiatives are uncoordinated and shaped by geopolitical competition, there is a danger they could lock countries into high-carbon paths for decades to come.

Talking to colleagues in Europe, there was a shared concern over an emerging dynamic that threatens to cleave the world into competing spheres. Getting China, the EU and the United States to sit down and talk will take bold efforts in the current climate. But if we want a twenty-first century that is stable and sustainable, a G3 would be a good place to start.

China's Ties with the Global South Show a Different World Order Is Possible⁴⁹

China's trade and partnerships with the Global South are a case study of what multilateral efforts can do. Together we can forge ahead on a new path and build a more inclusive, more collaborative global order.

The Global South's quest for a more equitable world order gained fresh momentum at the 22nd Doha Forum in early December 2024. During the two-day event, world leaders gathered to discuss China's evolving role in international development. The high-level dialogue came at a critical time as the global trade landscape faces new uncertainties.

As major economies like the United States and the European Union signal a return to protectionist policies—with tariffs on Chinese electric vehicles, solar panels, and semiconductors as well as carbon border adjustment mechanisms—China's recent announcement that it would cut tariffs for more than 40 least developed countries has drawn significant attention.

This strategic approach was evident at the sub-forum session “China's Role in the Rising Global South: Redefining the Future World Order” where leaders from around the world shared perspectives on development partnerships, highlighting a stark contrast to the bleak future of international economic engagement.

China's expanding engagement with the Global South represents more than just trade statistics; it represents an alternative model of international cooperation. While serving as the primary trading partner for at least 120 countries, China has moved beyond mere commercial relationships to establish comprehensive development partnerships.

The Belt and Road Initiative, now encompassing 150 nations, has become a platform for sustainable development beyond simply building infrastructure. Bolstered by institutions such as the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, the New Development Bank, and the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership, China's approach is reshaping how developing nations think about economic partnerships.

The impact of this cooperation model is already evident. Rwandan President Paul Kagame revealed that his country's trade with China surged from US\$30 million to over US\$150 million after recent tariff reductions, with a remarkable 274% growth since 2018.

Rwandan farmers now earn US\$4 more for every kilogram of coffee beans sold to China. The partnership has also led to significant infrastructure development, including hydropower stations and the renovation of the Masaka Hospital.

Even more telling was Namibian President Nangolo Mbumba's observation about Chinese companies undertaking essential infrastructure projects such as building roads and opening mines.

Trade relations between China and Namibia are rooted in equitable cooperation rather than coercion. Namibia has increased its agricultural exports to China,

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including beef, mutton, and dried fruit. Namibia is also exploring innovative partnerships in green hydrogen development. These practical outcomes represent a fundamental shift in how Global South nations view development partnerships.

China is essentially rewriting the traditional rules of development cooperation. Over the past two decades, emerging markets and developing economies have come to account for 80% of global growth. BRICS nations have been at the forefront of this endeavor, making up around 35% of global gross domestic product.

The economic influence of countries within BRICS has increasingly translated into diplomatic capacity, as evidenced by China's successful mediation between Saudi Arabia and Iran and its role in uniting rival political factions in Palestine.

Strong endorsements from Global South leaders at the Doha Forum reflect this evolving dynamic. Barbadian Prime Minister Mia Mottley, invoking the spirit of the Bandung Conference, has articulated what many developing nations have long felt but rarely expressed: the Western monopoly on defining the global order must end.

Her belief that all nations, regardless of size, should have a voice in shaping the multipolar world order found immediate resonance with other leaders, particularly as developing nations seek to chart development paths that align with their specific needs and circumstances.

Honduran Foreign Minister Eduardo Enrique Reina's perspective was particularly revealing. He highlighted how major powers that once benefited from relations with China are now discouraging other nations from pursuing similar partnerships.

As Namibia's Mbumba succinctly put it, "We Africans are learning how to do things for ourselves and with whom to do them," from a position of strength. This growing confidence, coupled with the Rwandan president's note that Chinese partnerships don't "come with a lot of strings attached," reflects a fundamental shift in international relationships.

The cooperation between China and Global South countries shows remarkable potential in innovative sectors, as highlighted at the Doha Forum, which was themed around "The Innovative Imperative." Leaders explored multiple areas of collaboration where developing nations are bridging technology gaps while pursuing sustainable development. Climate-related technology, the digital economy, and green energy transitions are becoming new pillars of cooperation.

There are already tangible results across the continent: Chinese solar technology has helped African households gain better access to electricity, digital payment systems developed through Chinese-African cooperation are boosting financial inclusion and joint forums are accelerating the development of drought-resistant crops.

While some of them start small, these initiatives are creating transformative changes in people's daily lives and laying the groundwork for sustainable development.

The vision emerging from the Doha Forum signals a new chapter in international development. As Barbados' Mottley expressed, a more inclusive world order is taking shape—one that requires collaborative efforts from multiple global institutions. While China has played a pioneering role, the ultimate goal remains a truly open and cooperative global development ecosystem.

Institutions like the World Bank, Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, and other multilateral organizations must work together to support the developmental needs of the Global South. The future lies not in competing narratives but in collaborative solutions. By uniting diverse strengths, we can forge more equitable global partnerships.

BRICS Is Not Anti-West, It Just Wants a Fairer World Order⁵⁰

In championing economic inclusivity and strategic autonomy, pioneering financial innovation and promoting peace, BRICS is a force for good.

The 16th BRICS summit, held as the world marks 80 years since the Bretton Woods agreement, heralds an important development that is often misunderstood: BRICS is not an anti-West bloc but a new platform to enable developing countries to engage in global governance.

Involving more than 20 heads of state, the summit showed how emerging economies can contribute to global development. While BRICS—named after early members Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa—represents around 30% of the world economy and nearly half of the population, it has no intention of replacing existing institutions instead it seeks to enrich them through constructive reform and complementary development.

In our evolving multipolar world order, BRICS represents one of the first major platforms led by developing countries for promoting development. While this might suggest competition with existing institutions, healthy competition drives innovation and progress.

The grouping's distinctiveness lies in three key characteristics.

First, its economic inclusivity brings together countries at varying stages of development. From major emerging economies to developing nations, all can engage in practical cooperation with no ideological prerequisite.

This diversity, rather than being a weakness, shows the platform's unique strength in fostering collaboration across the spectrum of development. The recent expansion of BRICS' membership to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, and the United Arab Emirates exemplifies this inclusive approach. With 30 other countries reportedly expressing interest in joining, BRICS is not a closed club but a supportive platform committed to mutual aid and cooperation.

Second, BRICS continues to pioneer innovative solutions in global economic governance. Take for example, BRICS Pay, an international payment system under development designed to prevent monetary weaponization.

There is also the Shanghai-headquartered New Development Bank, which has approved over US\$35 billion for 105 development projects. In Kazan, BRICS members endorsed the bank's plan to fund more projects in local currencies to avoid exchange-rate fluctuations. The bank has also funded projects in crucial areas including sustainable infrastructure, clean energy, digital transformation, and social infrastructure, with a particular focus on meeting developing countries' needs.

This serves as an early-stage investment vehicle for developing countries, offering attractive opportunities for growth and cooperation, while complementing international financial institutions.

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Finally, BRICS upholds the principle of strategic autonomy. Members maintain their independence in choosing developmental paths suited to their national conditions. Beyond economic cooperation, BRICS countries are increasingly playing a role in promoting global peace and stability, amid a turbulent international landscape and regional wars.

This is exemplified by the “Friends of Peace” initiative, launched by China and Brazil, an inclusive framework for dialogue on regional conflicts such as Russia’s war on Ukraine. Seventeen countries, including NATO member Türkiye, are part of the group. The signing of a joint communiqué by 13 of these countries after a meeting in September further reinforced the coalition’s commitment to dialogue and peaceful resolution.

The foundation for this was laid by China and Brazil through their six-point peace plan, which shows BRICS members’ growing role in conflict resolution.

BRICS leaders have also taken their own diplomatic steps to mitigate conflict. Notably, last year South African President Cyril Ramaphosa and other African heads of state visited both Russia and Ukraine to mediate.

The recent BRICS summit held in Kazan, Russia, further highlighted this commitment to peace-building, particularly through the China-India meeting on the summit sidelines, where both leaders showed a willingness to pull back from border tensions, displaying how the two largest nations of the Global South can work together.

This cooperation between two of Asia’s giants adds tremendous stability to the BRICS platform and strengthens its role in promoting peace. The evolution aligns with Chinese President Xi Jinping’s advocacy of BRICS as a force for peace, innovation, and equitable global governance.

As BRICS emerges as an indispensable force in global economic growth and the voice of the Global South, some Western countries feel apprehensive. Yet BRICS only seeks to build a more equitable world order. BRICS has become a crucial platform enabling Global South nations to engage more effectively with major institutions such as the Group of 7, the Group of 20, the European Union, the Association of Southeast Asian Nations and the African Union.

However, the platform’s appeal extends beyond the Global South. French President Emmanuel Macron was reportedly interested in joining last year’s summit, while this year, United Nations Secretary-General Antonio Guterres was among the attendees. This reflects a broader truth about global governance: just as the G7 would benefit from including more emerging economies in its meetings, BRICS welcomes developed nations’ engagement—marking a natural evolution toward true multilateralism.

For the Global South, BRICS is an important platform for cooperation and development, including establishing free trade zones and industrial estates, as well as boosting poverty alleviation, the green power transition, and infrastructure enhancement. The economic cooperation espoused by BRICS members is more needed than the military or security alliances emerging in our more geopolitically challenging world.

As the world moves toward multipolarity, the emergence of BRICS as yet another pole can help to diversify and democratize international politics. Its efforts can help

strengthen UN institutions and improve global governance by promoting a fairer world order. Economic cooperation among BRICS members can also contribute to more balanced and inclusive economic growth globally.

BRICS will continue to address the world's pressing challenges, from wars to climate change. This is, ultimately, a platform that enriches global governance by embracing diversity and fostering dialogue among nations, contributing vitally to a more balanced and sustainable world order.

How China and the West Can Join Hands to Truly Help Africa⁵¹

In the spirit of multilateralism, China and Western nations should adopt a third-party cooperation model to help African countries address their many challenges.

As the world continues to wrestle with unprecedented global challenges, Africa's development has become a focal point for international cooperation. While collaboration between Africa and China has made significant strides in recent decades, it is now time for a more inclusive approach to empowering the African continent.

The recent Forum on China-Africa Cooperation summit highlighted the strength of their relations, with China announcing a 10-point action plan to deepen its partnership with Africa. However, to truly unlock Africa's potential, we must now expand this cooperation to more global partners, leveraging the strengths and resources of a wider range of nations and institutions.

Despite the geographical distance between China and Africa, the friendship between the two has a deep and enduring history. Since the founding of the People's Republic of China, China has extended broad support to African countries. The Tanzania-Zambia Railway, built in the early 1970s, stands out as a significant example of this early cooperation—a project in which my father proudly participated.

Over the years, collaboration between China and Africa has transitioned beyond infrastructure to supporting African countries working to reach their national development goals. The focus has expanded to sustainable, high-quality development, including green programs.

Since 2021, China has participated in more than 120 climate projects in Africa. Also, to ensure the continued implementation of these programs, as of the end of 2019, China had deployed peacekeeping forces or observers to at least four African regions, reflecting a commitment to the continent's stability and growth.

Africa, a continent with the world's youngest population and largest number of developing countries, boasts abundant labor and rich natural resources. However, historical factors such as colonial rule have impeded Africa's economic development.

As the world's largest developing economy, China has engaged in broad cooperation with Africa. Now, to fully unleash Africa's development potential and address its challenges, the participation of a broader segment of the international community is needed.

Encouragingly, some Western countries have come together to launch cooperative initiatives, such as the European Union's Global Gateway program and the US-led "Build Back Better World" initiative that was adopted by the Group of Seven in 2021 and rebranded as Partnership for Global Infrastructure and Investment a year later.

The increased attention and investment from major powers have led to diversified development initiatives and enhanced economic partnerships across African nations, catalyzing growth in key sectors such as infrastructure, technology, and sustainable energy. However, challenges have emerged within these international projects. Some

⁵¹ First published on September 23, 2024 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

suggest that initiatives like the Global Gateway and Build Back Better World were introduced in part to counterbalance the international influence of China's Belt and Road Initiative in Global South countries.

In connection with these projects, political rhetoric related to competition with China has occasionally surfaced. Moreover, some Western projects emphasize their countries' comparative advantages and values, which may not always align with the immediate developmental needs of African nations. For instance, while the Global Gateway strategy focuses on clean energy and digital industries, which are important long-term goals, it may not fully address Africa's more pressing concerns such as industrialization, food security, and pan-African integration.

As a result, despite widespread recognition of Africa's global importance and development potential among Western countries, the sometimes conflicting approaches and political undertones in their strategies may hinder effective cooperation and lead to inefficient resource allocation.

To truly drive African development, it is crucial for all parties involved to prioritize Africa's actual needs and foster genuine collaboration over competition.

Fortunately, some Western countries are gradually adopting a more open attitude toward foreign aid, viewing China's development projects in Africa more favorably and engaging in active collaboration. This growing willingness to cooperate marks a positive step toward more coordinated aid efforts that can better address Africa's developmental challenges.

For instance, China is exploring third-party cooperation with France, encouraging companies from both countries to jointly participate in projects. This mode of cooperation has shown benefits for China, France, and African nations alike. A notable example is the collaboration on the operation of the Kribi Deep Seaport in Cameroon, which is not only of economic benefit to Cameroon but also landlocked African countries, including the Central African Republic and Chad.

Interestingly, Japan has emerged as another important participant in third-party market cooperation with China. The first China-Japan Third-Party Market Cooperation Forum, held in Beijing in October 2018, opened up more opportunities for businesses from both countries to collaborate in Africa. While competition between Chinese and Japanese companies in Africa exists, there is also recognition of the potential of mutually beneficial partnerships.

Multilateral institutions also play a crucial role in this collaborative approach. The Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB), with its diverse global membership, has established cooperative foundations with the African Development Bank as well as the World Bank. The AIIB's involvement in projects like Egypt's issuing of a sustainable "panda bond" demonstrates how international financial institutions can work together to support Africa's inclusive growth and green development goals.

As we move forward, it is imperative that we build upon the strong foundation we already have in China-Africa cooperation to create a truly global partnership for African development.

By combining China's experience, the technological experience of developed Western countries, the expertise of multilateral institutions, and, most importantly,

the vision and leadership of African nations themselves, we can create a more effective and sustainable model of development cooperation. This collaborative approach would not only serve Africa's interests but also contribute to global stability and prosperity.

How China Can Step Up to Its Responsibilities in a Rising Global South⁵²

As the rise of the Global South brings opportunities and risks to South-South cooperation, China must boost dialogue, work more with India, and drive North-South cooperation.

The importance of this week's BRICS summit cannot be understated, especially given the possibility of the expansion of a grouping that already comprises Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa. This moment is also indicative of the wider rise of the Global South.

In February 2023, the Munich Security Conference added a panel discussion on how the Global North can better cooperate with the Global South. At the G7 summit in May, host Japan pushed to strengthen the Group of Seven's ties with the Global South and specifically invited the leaders of several developing countries to the Hiroshima meeting.

"The Global South is becoming more visible—and influential—in every arena," said *Foreign Policy* magazine at the start of the year.

While the Voice of Global South Summit, a virtual meeting hosted by India earlier this year, was attended by more than 100 countries, there is no universally accepted definition of which countries exactly comprise the Global South. There are, for instance, Global South countries in the geographic North, and vice versa.

Yet this flexibility reflects the nature of the Global South, a community where states recognize in one another their similar situations. Economically, the community is developing and looking to improve. Politically, it is a multilateral alliance with diversified values and interests.

Despite the escalation of the Ukraine crisis and global political divisions, most countries have chosen to neither take sides nor join the strategic suppression of Russia. Clearly, Global South countries prefer to keep an independent foreign policy and a non-aligned position.

In recent years, major powers in the Global North have introduced initiatives to strengthen their connection with the Global South, often in hope of obtaining greater geopolitical benefits. These include the US-led Build Back Better World and the EU's Global Gateway.

Compared to the United States, however, the European Union appears to have a more nuanced interest in the Global South. While safeguarding members' interests in former colonies, the EU also hopes to enhance its security in energy and food by "derisking." In essence, the EU sees a third path in a new global order, dominated by neither the United States nor China, and needs to build common interests with the Global South.

At the same time, India and Russia play important roles in Global South countries. India positions itself as a North-South power—deeply intertwined with the Global North in strategic goals and values, while remaining an integral part of the Global

⁵² First published on August 22, 2023 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

South, seeking to become a bridge in leading the community to build a new diplomatic equilibrium.

Russia's diplomatic focus, meanwhile, has been on former Soviet states, the Asia-Pacific, Middle East, and Africa. Their reliance on energy, food, chemical fertilizers, and other commodities from Russia makes decoupling difficult. Through engagement, Russia has strengthened its position and cooperation with the Global South.

With the rise of the Global South comes opportunities to deepen South-South cooperation. But any hasty moves can bring risks, intensify North-South tensions, and exacerbate confrontations worldwide. China, seen as a pivotal country in the Global South as far back as in 2004, should take on its due responsibilities.

First, it should encourage and support Global South think tanks and institutions, and jointly conduct research with other Global South countries to examine issues such as exchange mechanisms. Western countries have already established several Global South think tanks and research centers.

Second, a new world order aligned with the demands of the Global South should be proposed and promoted. The rise of the Global South may be an unstoppable trend, but the process will not be smooth. The looseness, fragility, and diversity of the community means it is less able to sidestep risks and more prone to infighting. To guard against exclusion, China should embrace developing countries, keep close ties with its partners, and work to enhance the cohesion of the Global South.

Third, China must work to improve relations with India to bolster the influence and function of BRICS. As a grouping, BRICS' economy has surpassed the G7 in purchasing power parity terms.

Sino-Indian relations have been stagnant for years, but with India having chaired the recent Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit and set to preside over the G20 summit in December, there is hope that relations will get better. Both China and India are in a position to work with other major developing countries and lead cooperation in the Global South to promote BRICS. Expansion will only enhance the impact of the "BRICS Plus" format in addressing the concerns of the Global South.

Fourth, China should hold more Global South forums to enhance official and non-governmental exchanges. Existing platforms include the Belt and Road Forum for International Cooperation, Forum on China-Africa Cooperation, and China-CELAC Forum with the Latin American and Caribbean states.

China should invite high-level officials and experts from industry and academia to hold more diverse Global South forums. Regularly held, these can facilitate standards for South-South cooperation and establish inclusive and equitable rules for cooperation in areas such as the digital economy, climate change, and sustainable development.

Finally, China should work on stronger, better, coordinated North-South cooperation. For many, China epitomizes the rising Global South. China's economic and technological cooperation with many countries in the Global South is also greater than that of developed countries.

Given China's experience in cooperating with developed countries, its role as a go-between might be more appealing to the Global North. In this sense, China

should consider enhancing North-South exchanges and cooperation, while avoiding an escalation of tensions.

As a country with both developing and developed elements, China could marry the interests of both communities to promote a more sustainable global development and better global governance.

How Modi's Visit to China Can Reshape Asia's Future⁵³

China and India, both ancient civilizations, and the world's most populous nations, have been at odds in recent years. As Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi prepared to visit China ahead of the 2025 SCO Summit in Tianjin, I reflected not only on how the two countries might prudently navigate their challenges and also the potential of a world where they can cooperate to meet shared objectives.

As Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi prepares to visit China for the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit in Tianjin, the world is watching closely. Modi's visit will be a historic opportunity to usher in a new era of cooperation between two ancient civilizations whose populations account for just under 35% of humanity, representing the world's second- and soon-to-be third-largest economies.

During Modi's recent meeting with Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi, both seemed to agree that India and China are partners, not rivals, and that the Asian century can't happen without bilateral cooperation.

The history between China and India runs deep, from ancient trade relations during the Kushan empire and Han dynasty to cultural exchanges such as the spread of Buddhism and the travels of Chinese monk Xuanzang. The two civilizations have long been engaged in dialogue, and the exchange of ideas, trade, and philosophy has only enriched both societies. The 1955 Bandung Conference was an example of one such exchange in the diplomatic realm.

This year marks the 75th anniversary of formal diplomatic relations. India was the first non-socialist bloc country recognized by the People's Republic of China in 1950. Now, more than ever, it's time to build on that legacy.

Both countries face shared development challenges to ensure prosperity for their people. India is the fastest-growing major economy and is also home to the world's largest youth population, as well as a rapidly growing innovation system and an expanding consumer base. China brings expertise in infrastructure, manufacturing, digital governance, and renewable energy. If the two powers work together, the possibilities are enormous.

China can play a constructive role in investing in India's next phase of growth. Importantly, India already serves as the largest recipient of funding from the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB).

By working within the AIIB framework, China and India can boost investment in key areas such as infrastructure, smart cities, clean energy, public health, and sustainable agriculture. With the combined power of 2.8 billion people, there's so much we can accomplish, from digital connectivity to climate action.

This is not a matter of one side "helping" the other, but of both nations leveraging complementary strengths. Together, the world's two most populous countries can become a cornerstone of stability and prosperity for Asia.

Just as importantly, closer ties between China and India could provide the bedrock for more democratic global governance. Both nations are central to BRICS, the

⁵³ First published on August 26, 2025 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

Group of 20, and the SCO. Through their vital roles in these organizations, they can advocate for reforms that empower developing countries and resist unilateral actions that destabilize global markets and institutions.

In a world of increasing geopolitical uncertainty, the need for such cooperation has never been more important. The unpredictability of US foreign policy is a case in point. India's earlier purchases of Russian oil at capped prices were once encouraged by Washington to avoid a global spike in energy costs. However, India is now facing new American tariffs for making those purchases.

Fortunately, China and India don't have to go it alone. Asia, adjusted for purchasing power parity, already represents more than two-fifths of the global economy.

If India joins the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership, effectively linking up with a broader economic coalition, regional integration and development would happen faster than people can imagine. India can take this step on its own terms with the support of China. Turbulence in the world system and disrupted global trade provide a stronger case for India's membership.

This is how the spirit of the Bandung Conference can be appreciated in today's context. In 1955, leaders from Asia and Africa came together in Bandung, Indonesia, to assert a vision of cooperation rooted in mutual respect, non-alignment, and peaceful development. Out of that conference came the Non-Aligned Movement.

Reviving the ethos of Bandung requires not only setting shared goals but also wisely managing present challenges. Unfortunately, the China-India border dispute has tested bilateral trust in recent years. It is worth remembering that, after the 1960s, tensions had not escalated for half a century before the Galwan Valley border clash.

Coexistence was the norm. To embrace this spirit again would be to honor Bandung's legacy while allowing both sides to focus on the promise of partnership. India and China agree that differences should not escalate into disputes. If peace can hold for 50 years, it can do so again.

As Wang noted during his visit to New Delhi, both sides seek to enhance cooperation on global challenges and oppose unilateral bullying. They have made progress in establishing a new consensus on how to manage the border and resolve disputes. These are important steps. But they must be matched by vision.

Modi's visit presents a good opportunity for the two sides to issue a joint communique or a cooperation road map. Such a framework could identify practical areas for cross-border collaboration. There is much room for progress in areas such as tourism, academic programs, investment deals, infrastructure development, the green transition, environmental protection, and coordinated technology governance on digital spaces, and artificial intelligence.

That vision—one focused on a shared agenda of green development, multilateralism, and peace—could take shape when Modi meets President Xi Jinping again this year. China and India are not only heirs to ancient wisdom but custodians of future possibility. The dragon and the elephant working together can create prosperity for Asia for decades to come through a partnership worthy of two great civilizations and, indeed, the world.

From ASEAN and G20 to APEC, as World Leaders Meet in Person Again, Three Reasons to Root for Multilateralism⁵⁴

The resumption of in-person high-level meetings for ASEAN, G20, and APEC provide proof that effective communication produces results, especially for middle powers.

Over the past two weeks, Asia has played host to the most intense sequence of multilateral summits since the pandemic began, as national leaders gathered for meetings organized by ASEAN, the G20, and APEC. Although overshadowed by geopolitical tensions, the meetings marked a welcome return to in-person summit diplomacy, and the better-than-expected outcomes show hope yet for multilateralism.

The conclaves began in Phnom Penh with the annual summit of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations. At the first such in-person events in almost three years, ASEAN leaders took the positive step of agreeing in principle to admit East Timor as the 11th member of the organization.

As leaders moved on to Bali for the Group of 20 summit, expectations were low after ministerial meetings in the run-up had failed to produce consensus. Earlier in the year, given fractures in the wake of Russia's invasion of Ukraine, there was a question mark over whether the G20 could even go ahead or survive in its existing form.

In the end, the summit surpassed expectations by producing a joint declaration after intense negotiations, with leaders finding the compromises necessary to unite in declaring that "today's era must not be of war" and pledging to uphold the multilateral system.

The summit also saw a positive face-to-face meeting between China's President Xi Jinping and US President Joe Biden, their first as leaders, signaling a willingness to halt the downward trajectory of China-US relations.

In Bangkok, the 21 leaders of the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum also pledged to uphold and strengthen the rules-based multilateral trading system. Importantly, the group agreed on a multi-year work plan for an Asia-Pacific free trade area.

Reflecting on these three summits, three takeaways give reason for cautious optimism that multilateralism can yet be revived and play a major role in solving our challenges.

First, and perhaps most obviously, the return of in-person summit diplomacy is a welcome uplift for global cooperation. Virtual formats played a useful interim role at the height of the pandemic, but were never a substitute for getting leaders in the same room. That is especially true when it comes to interactions on the sidelines, often as important as the main event. China's return to diplomacy at the highest level was a further boost, both for the nation and the rest of the world.

⁵⁴ First published on November 29, 2022 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

In addition to Xi's highly anticipated meeting with Biden, the Chinese leader met over a dozen other leaders at the G20 and APEC summits, including a warmer-than-expected first meeting with Japanese Prime Minister Fumio Kishida and his first meeting with an Australian prime minister since 2016.

Leaders got to meet their new counterparts for the first time or build on existing relationships, which can only help global cooperation.

The second takeaway is that as grave as our challenges are, the threat of escalating conflict and severe economic pressures on all nations seem to be focusing minds and increasing the willingness to engage and cooperate—out of necessity if nothing else.

The G20 summit was the second major one this year to surpass expectations after the 12th World Trade Organization Ministerial Conference in June surprised observers by agreeing on a plan to reform the organization and its dispute settlement mechanism. The G20 statement reiterated support for this WTO reform plan, which will be critical to get the free trade agenda back on track and provide a much-needed boost for the global economy.

Third, and perhaps most significantly for the long term, the recent summits marked an acceleration of the trend toward multipolarization in international diplomacy, and in particular, the rising influence of non-aligned “middle powers” to shape multilateral outcomes.

The middle powers represented at ASEAN, the G20, and APEC have huge stakes in avoiding a bifurcation of the global economy that might result from a new cold war. They don't want to be forced to pick sides, and many show a growing willingness and ability to build bridges and restore positive momentum for multilateralism.

Indonesia is a prime example. The country's strategic heft and non-aligned credibility make it well placed to bridge different camps. President Joko Widodo made a big political bet on the success of the G20 and has won praise for the deft diplomacy that kept the organization alive and got it to release a joint statement.

The Indian delegation reportedly also played a big role in achieving consensus on language in the statement, with the BRICS group (Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa)—as well as Indonesia—turning out to be crucial swing voters in securing the joint statement. One Indian official said it was “the first [G20] summit where developing nations shaped the outcome.”

There is scope for this trend to continue next year as middle powers continue to rise in stature, and India and Indonesia take over the presidency of the G20 and ASEAN, respectively. Brazil will host the G20 the year after.

Over in Sharm el-Sheikh at the COP27 UN climate summit, another middle power—the host Egypt—also won praise for helping to shepherd a historic financing deal for poor countries affected by climate change. But the ultimate failure to reach a commitment to phase down fossil fuels was a sobering reminder of the huge difficulties that remain in forging the global consensus needed to overcome our shared challenges.

How China Can Multilateralize the BRI⁵⁵

The Belt and Road Initiative is currently a loose collection of bilateral agreements, but multilateralizing how the organization is administered could strengthen the initiative.

At the end of 2022, 150 countries and 32 international organizations had signed more than 200 cooperation documents related to joint infrastructure projects with China under the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). Meanwhile, the 2022 work report to the 20th National Congress of the Communist Party of China suggested that China should promote opening up to the world and development. Anchoring the BRI in a multilateral framework could help China achieve these goals.

The BRI is an ambitious plan by China to build global infrastructure while connecting itself to trading partners. Since its launch, there have been diverse responses to it from the international community. Some countries welcomed the opportunity to form new trade routes, while others—notably, the United States—depicted it as a sign of China’s efforts to overturn the world order. Doubts about the Initiative also emerged around issues related to the environment, labor standards, transparency, government procurement, and social responsibility.

The BRI is largely built around China’s bilateral relations with other countries. Bilateral memorandums of understanding (MoUs) and joint statements supporting the initiative are the main forms of cooperation agreements that anchor the BRI. The legal terms in these agreements, though, are relatively weak. The validity periods stipulated in the MoUs are typically short and signatories can withdraw at any time. To a certain extent, MoUs have become a potentially unstable way for China to codify cooperation with other countries. They appear to be more political overtures than genuine commitments to economic and business cooperation.

Multilateral development of the BRI could increase its global reach and enable the Initiative to play a greater role as a new platform for global governance. China has launched a multi-level and diversified multilateral cooperation mechanism for the BRI and invited countries to participate and ensure its multilateral development.

It will be very difficult to attract support from some key international players in furthering the reach of the BRI. The United States, some of its allies, and those in the international community who are suspicious of Chinese “debt trap” diplomacy will undermine opportunities for China to expand its economic, strategic, and geopolitical power. Yet there are ways in which China could build trust and potentially lock in further multilateral cooperation.

First, international and multilateral structures for decision-making could be established to strengthen the BRI and manage how it provides infrastructure. If several countries were offered and accepted real responsibility over what is considered a Chinese initiative, this could involve establishing a BRI International Steering Committee. Invited countries could send representatives to participate in the committee, helping to form a new order of global and regional governance over the BRI.

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A BRI Steering Committee could be aligned with existing multilateral institutions of global and regional governance such as the G20 and the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation Forum. Countries could regularly gather to discuss BRI-related agenda items and carry out extensive exchanges and consultations. The agreements, plans, mechanisms, and projects jointly implemented would promote sequential development at various stages of BRI projects.

Second, the BRI could attract international organizations under the United Nations system to connect and participate in BRI projects. The initiative could encourage the United Nations to establish a BRI cooperation agency, giving full play to the bridging role and global influence of the United Nations. UN involvement in the BRI could also establish alliances with UN system agencies such as the United Nations Development Programme and the World Trade Organization. While the support of the United Nations would encourage participants, getting the support of the United Nations is likely to be difficult as the United States and certain other nations are likely to block UN agencies from assisting BRI.

Third, China could engage more developed countries in BRI third-party market cooperation and enhance its cooperation with the United States and Europe in infrastructure construction plans. China has signed cooperation agreements with France and Japan in third countries and such agreements could be expanded to other developed countries. Third-party market cooperation agreements emphasize complementarities, which include China's high-level production capacity, the advanced technology of developed countries and the infrastructure needs of developing countries. Bringing these together will provide a new model for high-quality joint construction of BRI projects and an effective means of promoting multilateralism. China could propose infrastructure cooperation between the BRI the EU-led Global Gateway and the US-led Build Back Better infrastructure initiatives—despite the Build Back Better plan being initially created to counter BRI.

Fourth, China could cautiously consider joining the Paris Club. The construction of the BRI involves huge sums of lending. China can greatly relieve the international community's doubts about the BRI if its lending practices follow internationally accepted rules. As an emerging creditor, China still lacks experience in managing and controlling external debt risks. The Paris Club enables regular communication between major creditor countries. China could consider joining the Paris Club and commit to following transparent and sustainable international lending rules. The move would help mitigate China's external debt risks and safeguard global financial stability.

Fifth, China could update the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) and encourage cooperation between international development banks and the BRI. Improving and renovating traditional infrastructure in developing countries, building digital infrastructure and enabling the green transition to achieve carbon neutrality offer potential areas of cooperation. Infrastructure spending can spur investment demand and boost job opportunities, though there are funding gaps.

China could expand the AIIB's target sectors and regions and provide support for eligible infrastructure investment projects worldwide. A repurposed AIIB could work with the World Bank and other continental development banks such as the

European Bank for Reconstruction and Development, Islamic Development Bank, and African Development Bank. So long as the global geopolitical environment allows, the arrangement could form an international, standardized, open, and transparent infrastructure development system and expand the supply networks for global products.

Since 2013, the BRI has grown from a vision to a series of bilateral arrangements. But the Initiative has the potential to serve as a multilateral platform for international infrastructure development. Harmonizing global infrastructure standards and norms of open development could enable more countries to participate in the BRI, help countries explore cooperative development opportunities and promote the recovery and development of the world economy.

China Can Embrace the Global Internet for Its Narrative⁵⁶

As the world emerged from the pandemic, China had the opportunity to increase its engagement through the world by encouraging institutions and individuals to strengthen their presence on global online media platforms.

In the early 1960s, Canadian media theorist Marshall McLuhan coined the term “global village” to describe how advances in communications technology bring people around the world closer together, enabling them to interact with each other more easily and experience the same events in real-time.

Six decades later, the internet has helped to realize this vision to a degree that would have surprised even McLuhan. But today’s digital global village is not always a harmonious one.

The internet helps human beings transcend physical barriers, connect, and build communities that would have never been possible otherwise. However, as shown by renewed concerns about online polarization and hate speech in the wake of Elon Musk’s tumultuous takeover of Twitter, the internet can also be a weapon to spread disinformation and division. That is especially true when it comes to contentious topics like China.

The lack of a healthy, balanced online discussion about China can be attributed to many factors. Geopolitical tensions, existing prejudice, and the dominance of Western media play a part, as does the phenomenon of “filter bubbles” that tend to expose people to information aligned with their existing beliefs and biases. However, the lack of Chinese voices on the global internet and the dearth of interaction between the Sinophone online sphere and the rest of the world also adds to the problem.

We are now entering an age when emerging technologies such as the metaverse, virtual and augmented reality, and the IoT mean that the digital global village will become more immersive and pervasive with every passing year. As geopolitical tensions and transnational challenges continue to rise, it is more important than ever that Chinese organizations and individuals make their voices heard and interact online to promote dialogue and mutual understanding between China and other countries.

China has a thriving digital ecosystem and culture of its own, and while there are obvious regulatory and linguistic obstacles to deeper engagement with the rest of the online world, there are still ways this can be achieved.

First, Chinese organizations such as think tanks, universities, and social organizations can upgrade their international online presence and be more proactive in engaging foreign audiences. At present, even major institutions are often absent from key global platforms.

For example, a 2021 study of 40 leading Chinese think tanks found that 65% do not have an account on Twitter, Facebook, YouTube, Instagram, or LinkedIn, while only 7% used all five of these channels.

To deepen international engagement, Chinese institutions can develop user-friendly English websites, open accounts on key global platforms, and share content

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such as articles and short videos. Tools like machine translation and speech recognition have significantly reduced the cost of creating content accessible for foreign audiences. Partnering with overseas organizations or platforms is another way to reach more people.

The second way that China can play a more active role in the digital global village is to empower individuals from all walks of life to share their stories and interact with global audiences via social media networks.

One striking example is the success of a new generation of global internet celebrities from rural China. Food vlogger Dianxi Xiaoge has racked up nearly 10 million subscribers to her YouTube channel by sharing traditional recipes and images of bucolic life in her native Yunnan. Even her dog, Dawang, has over 450,000 subscribers.

Influencers like Dianxi Xiaoge present a slice of life far removed from the urban industrial China that foreign audiences are usually exposed to, helping to convey the diversity of the country and confound narratives that reduce the lives of 1.4 billion people to tropes or political issues. As the mainland reopens, there is now also a chance to encourage foreign influencers, experts, and young people to visit and share direct experiences of China with audiences back home.

My third suggestion is that individuals and organizations embrace the metaverse and explore ways to use this collective virtual space to promote exchange and mutual understanding between China and the rest of the world.

The metaverse will become an increasingly important realm for creativity, collaboration, and cultural exchange. The pandemic has offered a glimpse of this potential. Museums and art galleries created immersive experiences that gave people on the other side of the world a chance to browse their exhibits. Governments are also getting in on the act.

Seoul is working with local IT companies to develop spaces where virtual visitors can experience K-pop culture, and last year, Barbados became the first country to announce it will open an embassy in the metaverse. China should be involved in these emerging worlds and the formation of the international conventions needed to guide their healthy development.

Rather than physical obstacles, in today's world, what separates people is often cognitive barriers and prejudice toward different civilizations. Its reputation may be tarnished, but the internet still holds immense potential as a stage for dialogue, exchange, and learning between different countries.

China's future development and globalization are closely linked to its participation in the evolving online sphere. Our civilization has a long tradition of inclusiveness and openness, something that has often coincided with periods of great strength such as during the Tang and Song dynasties. As we enter a new era of national flourishing, China would do well to draw on these traditions and play an active role in building a more open and inclusive global village.

US Concerns about China's Data Security Should Be Addressed, But Not with a TikTok Ban⁵⁷

Despite numerous commitments to respecting data sovereignty and strict data protection measures, data security regarding China is still a major issue in the United States. Pragmatism on the TikTok issue could help to rebuild trust and signal that both sides can handle complex issues.

At the heart of the intense scrutiny surrounding TikTok in the United States is the question of whether the Chinese government can access US data through TikTok or its Chinese parent company, ByteDance. Amid the numerous reports and analyses following the House hearing on TikTok, one key Chinese initiative has been absent from the US debate, yet it could prove to be crucial.

While concerns about US TikTok data potentially falling into Chinese government hands are not unfounded, the evidence is lacking. A 2021 Citizen Lab report said there was no overt data transmission to the Chinese government by TikTok, although it could not determine what happens after data enters TikTok servers.

TikTok CEO Chew Shou Zi testified before a Congressional panel that "TikTok has never shared, or received a request to share, US user data with the Chinese government. Nor would TikTok honour such a request if one were ever made." Members of Congress largely remained skeptical, particularly regarding the last statement.

This is not surprising given the current climate of distrust between the United States and China. Skeptics point to Chinese laws that state "all organisations and citizens shall support, assist, and cooperate with national intelligence efforts in accordance with law" and interpret it as ByteDance being legally obliged to turn over TikTok data upon request.

Four points should be considered. First, the Chinese government has repeatedly stated that its laws do not permit the acquisition of foreign data in this manner. In March 2019, then Premier Li Keqiang said during a press conference that asking Chinese companies to "spy" on other countries is "not consistent with Chinese law."

Second, what many Congress members perceive as enabling Chinese government spying through its companies is a result of different legislative traditions. Chinese laws are often seen as broad and vague if viewed through the lens of common law because they are modeled after civil law countries' legislation. China requires broadly drafted laws and regulations to accommodate local conditions.

Third, China's position on data protection is actually stronger than the Cloud Act.⁵⁸ Passed during former US President Donald Trump's administration, the act

⁵⁷ First published on April 4, 2023 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

⁵⁸ China says in the Ad Hoc Committee to Elaborate a Comprehensive International Convention on Countering the Use of Information and Communications Technologies for Criminal Purposes that "States shall not directly collect the data stored in foreign States from enterprises or individuals or by technical means bypassing network security protection measures if such measures are against the laws of that Foreign State."

says companies subject to US jurisdiction can be compelled, pursuant to a court order, to produce data subject to their control regardless of where the data is stored.

Fourth, China has made an international pledge not to request overseas data from Chinese companies. In September 2020, China unveiled the Global Initiative on Data Security. It calls for, among other things, countries to handle data security in a “comprehensive, objective, and evidence-based manner” and respect other countries’ sovereignty in how they handle data.⁵⁹

A plain reading means that, in the case of TikTok, China will not request that TikTok data be stored in China. China’s position is that it respects the sovereignty, jurisdiction, and governance of US data and will not obtain TikTok data located in the United States through ByteDance, TikTok, their employees, or anyone else without US permission.

The initiative attempts to establish China’s data security narrative and reassure foreign nations. Zhang Ming, head of China’s mission to the European Union, referenced the initiative in a 2020 interview, saying that “we never ask Chinese companies to break the laws of the host countries by handing over overseas data to the Chinese government.” Judging from the mainstream US discourse, it seems likely that some politicians and pundits are unaware of the initiative. In any case, the initiative rarely appears in discussions.

In a more optimistic era, TikTok could have been celebrated as a symbol of success reflecting the deep ties between the world’s two largest economies. Regrettably, it has now become a point of contention, with Washington reportedly threatening a ban unless a divestment takes place, a move that has received firm opposition from Beijing.

The two nations already face enough challenges and should avoid exacerbating tensions in repeating a showdown similar to the one surrounding Huawei.

There is a constructive way to navigate this minefield. Washington could signal to Beijing, through backchannels if necessary, its intention to resolve the matter based on pragmatism.

In turn, China could incorporate the Global Initiative on Data Security into domestic laws and regulations, amending or officially interpreting laws accordingly. Neither side wishes to appear “weak” domestically, but both have interests in finding a compromise.

TikTok reports a base of 150 million users in the United States. A ban or blocking of further downloads would be extreme and potentially politically fraught for US

⁵⁹ The Global Initiative on Data Security says—States should encourage companies to abide by laws and regulations of the State where they operate. States should not request domestic companies to store data generated and obtained overseas in their own territory.

States should respect the sovereignty, jurisdiction, and governance of data of other States, and shall not obtain data located in other States through companies or individuals without other States’ permission.

Should States need to obtain overseas data out of law enforcement requirement such as combating crimes, they should do it through judicial assistance or other relevant multilateral and bilateral agreements. Any bilateral data access agreement between two States should not infringe upon the judicial sovereignty and data security of a third State.

President Joe Biden. As Representative Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez said, it is “putting the cart before the horse.”

An evidence-based approach does not justify a ban. For China, after almost three years of promoting the Global Initiative on Data Security internationally, and proactively implementing key aspects of it domestically, this is not about appeasing the United States but a logical step to further strengthen its global appeal and serve Chinese interests.

The latest central economic work conference in Beijing stated that China supports Big Tech companies in fully displaying their capabilities to boost economic growth, job creation, and international competition. Codifying the global initiative would concretely and cost-effectively strengthen internet companies as well as Huawei, drone maker DJI, gene testing giant BGI, and even carmakers.

With data ubiquitous in Chinese technology and products, legislation alleviating potential concerns will be welcomed worldwide. Pragmatism from both sides regarding TikTok could also serve as a starting point for rebuilding trust and signaling that they can handle complex issues.

Finally, Beijing does not hold the key to addressing broader US online privacy concerns, such as questionable content, addictive algorithms, and the impact on teenagers' mental health. They are not unique to TikTok.

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Part III

Globalization and Economics: Tweaking the Sputtering Engine of Global Growth

Globalization and economic growth have made the world more stable and more prosperous than at any point in human history. However, a number of factors have caused the engine of global growth to slow and begin to show signs of wear. It is time to examine, as a global community, how to repair and tweak that engine so that we may enter a new era of continued prosperity and stability for all nations.